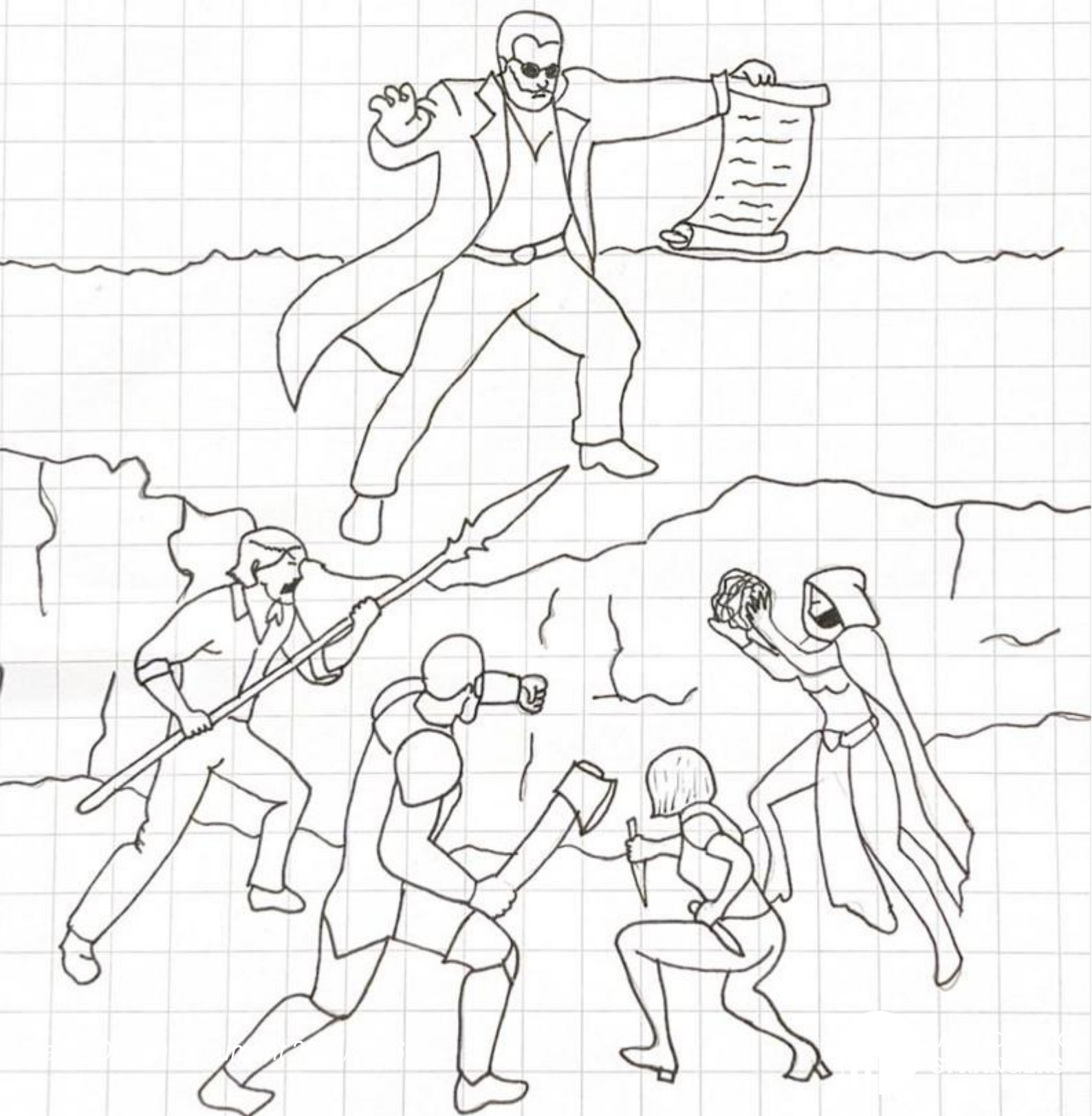
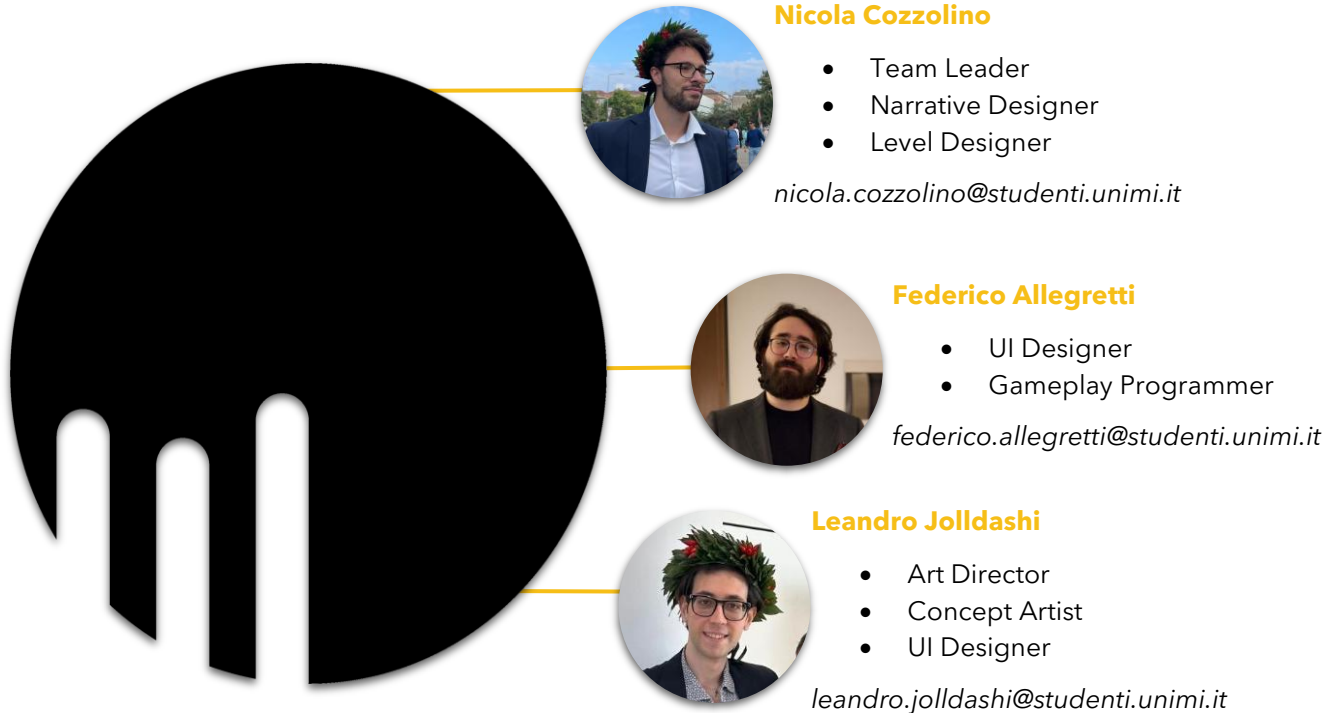


PUNCHLINE:

A Literal Adventure



Wandering Strangers Team



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1. Design History

When	Who	What
25/03/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	First Story (Synopsis, Introduction and Complete story)
26/03/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Vision Statement, Game logline, First NPCs, Backstory
30/03/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Backstory completed, Narrative devices
30/03/2026	Federico Allegretti	3. Audience, Platform and Marketing chapter (Top Performer, System requirements)
31/03/2026	Federico Allegretti	3. Audience, Platform and Marketing chapter (Psycho, Age, Gender, Geographic demographic)
01/04/2026	Federico Allegretti	3. Audience, Platform and Marketing chapter (Platform, Legal Analysis)
01/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	2.Gameplay Synopsis
01/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Finished Overview 5.1
01/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Started Gameplay description 5.2
02/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Corrected the Combo part in 5.2
03/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	8. Game World
04/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	6.2 NPCs, Summary added
07/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	6.2 NPCs (Ink Monsters added)
08/04/2026	Federico Allegretti	5.3.1 User Interfaces
09/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	5.2 Finito e tradotto il paragrafo
09/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	5.3 Mapping of Controller for the game
11/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Added in 6.2 NPCs Albert Behavior and Boss fight, Added 5.4.1 Punchline: A Literal Adventure Main Story, 5.4.2 New Game Plus, 5.4.3 DLCs and 5.4.4 Achievements
11/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	5.3.2 Rules
11/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	5.3.3 Scoring /winning conditions
12/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Finished 5.4.1 Punchline: A Literal Adventure Main Story, 5.4.3 New Game Plus, 5.4.4 DLCs and 5.4.4 Achievements
12/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Specified the dodge behavior
13/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Reworked 5.3 Controls, Added World Diagram in 5.5 Levels, added 5.4.2 Codex, 6.2 NPCs Finished.
14/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Concluded 5.2 Gameplay description, 5.5.1 Van, 10 Prototype.
14/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Adjusted in 6.1 the character description

15/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Completed 5.5 Levels with 5.5.2 Flyleaf level and 5.5.2 Albert Boss Fight.
15/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Done all the drawings of the characters, the villain
15/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Combo Link fire tornado
15/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Concept Art first page
15/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Added 9 Media List
15/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	Added Music inspiration to the media list
16/04/2026	Nicola Cozzolino	Added attack and L-ink combos' example in 6.1, Prologue cinematic storyboard, Team composition page.
17/04/2026	Wandering Strangers	Final revision and style makeover.
17/04/2026	Leandro Jolldashi	added the remaining images for the NPCs and enemies for reference

2. Vision Statement

Punchline: A Literal Adventure is a top-down 3D cooperative beat 'em up for 2 to 4 players, designed to deliver fast, accessible, and highly replayable sessions. The gameplay is intuitive from the very first minute, featuring simple and readable controls that welcome casual players, while still offering depth through ability combinations, team synergy, and progressive mastery.

During one of their Book Trips, the members of the Four Wheels Book Club uncover a forbidden manuscript known as *Sealed Legends*. Against the group's better judgment, their leader, Albert Redfield, breaks the ancient seal, freeing an ancient fairy. As a reward for releasing her from centuries of self-imprisonment, Aria, the Fairy of Books, grants Albert the power to summon ink-born creatures from the pages of books. However, what begins as a gift quickly turns into a curse, as Albert uses this power to twist stories to his will.

Aria then grants the remaining club members the ability to channel the powers of literature's greatest heroes to stop him.

Their journey begins aboard their trusted van, traveling across a world reshaped by corrupt narratives. Each location reflects a fractured story, where familiar tales are distorted into dangerous battlegrounds filled with ink-born enemies. As players progress, they uncover the lore behind these stories, strengthening their connection to the heroes they channel and unlocking new abilities.

At the core of the experience lies cooperation. Each character wields unique powers inspired by iconic literary heroes, designed to complement one another and create powerful synergies. The system actively encourages teamwork through shared combos, coordinated abilities, and role interplay, allowing players to experiment with different team compositions and strategies.

The goal is to create a cooperative experience that is easy to pick up, rewarding to master, and deeply rooted in both action-driven gameplay and meaningful social interaction.

2.1 Game logline

Become legendary heroes, master powerful L-Ink Combos, and fight at full throttle to stop a corrupted storyteller from rewriting reality!

2.2 Gameplay Synopsis

Punchline is a **cooperative beat 'em up** with a linear story, in which players fight their way through waves of enemies and environmental puzzles. Each player can choose one of four characters, each equipped with unique abilities and a specific role within the party.

The game is designed to offer a deeper cooperative experience compared to other titles in the same genre, actively encouraging player collaboration. One of the main key features is the **L-Ink Combos**, where players' special moves combine to generate powerful and synergistic effects.

2.2.1 Beat 'em up

The game falls within the beat 'em up genre, focusing on combat against large numbers of enemies, primarily through melee attacks or bladed weapons, supported by some ranged abilities. Player skills play a central role, proving more impactful than raw statistics alone.

Unlike traditional cooperative beat 'em ups, where players share the same move set, in **Punchline** each of the four playable characters has a unique set of abilities. This not only reflects their respective literary hero but also defines their role within the party, such as offensive, defensive, or support (see [section 5.2.4 Character Archetypes](#)).

2.2.2 Cooperative

Many cooperative beat 'em ups allow players to complete levels together without offering interdependence. Players often end up splitting the screen and engaging enemies independently, effectively playing as if they were alone. This is largely because such games are designed to function in singleplayer as well, without making cooperation a core mechanic.

Punchline, on the other hand, is designed from the ground up as a cooperative experience. The game actively encourages collaboration through multiple systems: asymmetric puzzles that require coordination, L-Ink Combos that reward player synchronization, and the ability to revive fallen teammates, introducing elements of risk management and mutual support.

2.2.3 L-Ink Combos

The L-Ink Combo System represents one of the game's main innovations. These are combined attacks that are triggered when specific abilities from two players interact, generating effects that are more powerful and unique compared to the original moves.

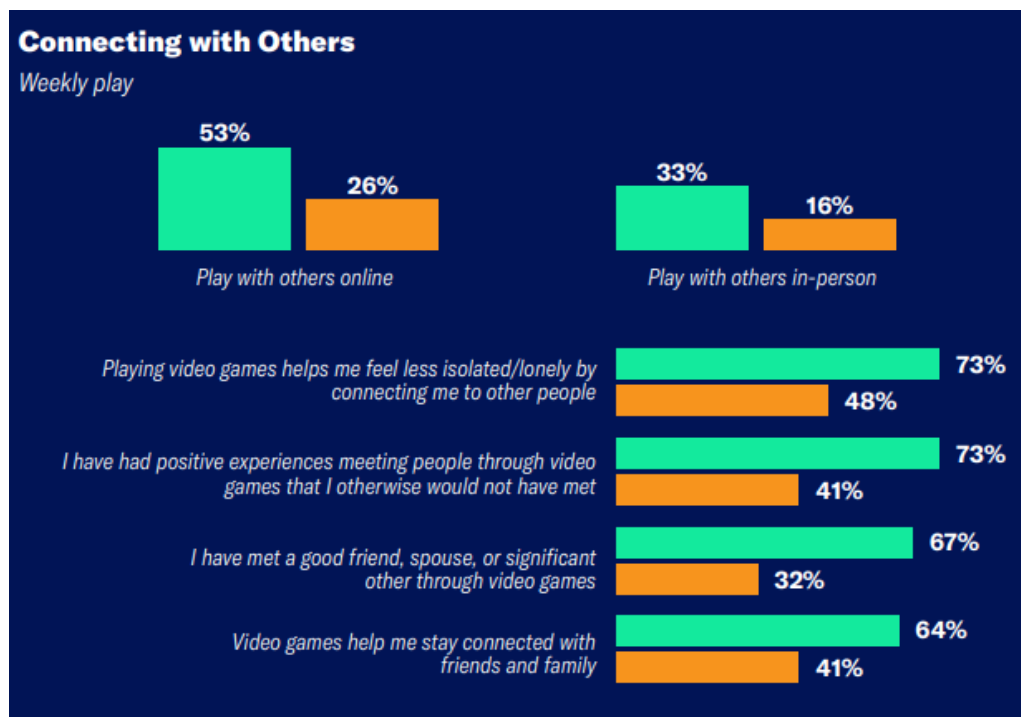
This mechanic is introduced in the early stages of the game through a dedicated tutorial and is progressively expanded as players unlock new abilities. A list of available combinations will be accessible in the Codex. This system encourages players to communicate and plan their actions, making coordination a key element in overcoming more complex enemies and boss fights.

3. Audience, Platform, and Marketing

3.1 Target Audience

3.1.1 Psycho-demographic

Punchline is primarily designed for Socializers, according to Bartle's Taxonomy of Player Types. The game's core philosophy revolves around cooperation, communication, and shared experiences rather than individual performance. Every major gameplay system has been designed to encourage players to interact, coordinate, and create memorable moments together, both during combat and between missions.



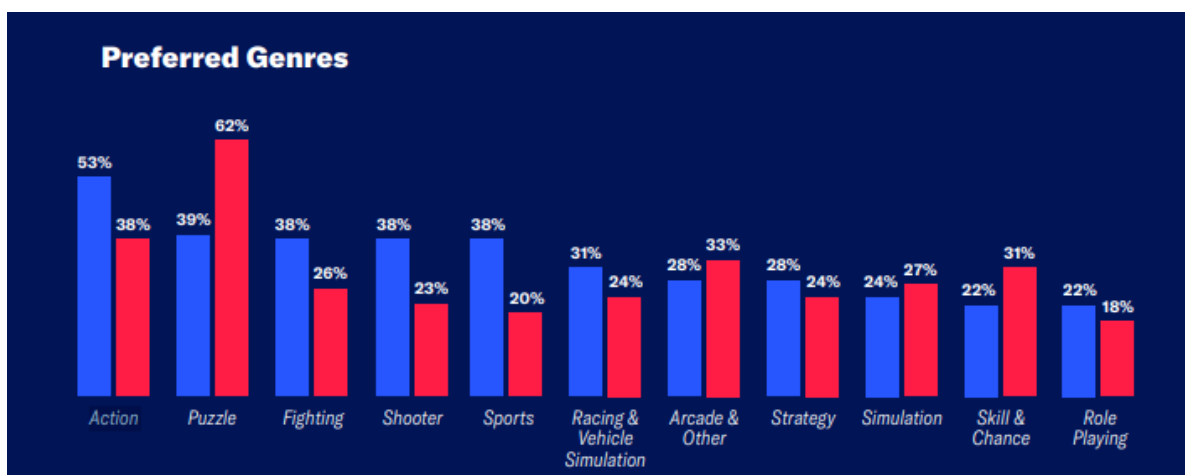
This design direction is also supported by recent player research. According to the *Power of Play 2025 Global Report*, **64% of players** under 35 and **41% of gamers** over 55 agree that video games help them stay connected with friends and family, while **73% of gamers** under 35 and **48% of players** over 55 report that video games help them feel less isolated by connecting them with other people. Furthermore, **74% of players believe games improve teamwork** and collaboration skills, while **74% believe they improve communication skills**, demonstrating that cooperative experiences represent an important motivation for modern players.

Although Socializers represent the primary target audience, Punchline also contains features that appeal to the remaining Bartle player types.

Socializers	Socializers are the audience for which Punchline has been primarily designed. They enjoy cooperating with friends, sharing memorable moments, and building experiences together. L-Ink Combos reward communication and synchronization, while environmental puzzles encourage players to actively discuss strategies instead of simply defeating enemies. Character customization, unlockable costumes, emotes, and the Van hub all provide opportunities for self-expression and casual interaction between missions, making cooperation central to the overall experience.
Killers	Killers are the least represented player type within Punchline's design. Since the game is entirely cooperative and does not include competitive multiplayer modes, it offers relatively few incentives for players primarily motivated by defeating other human opponents. However, more experienced players can still challenge themselves through higher New Game Plus difficulties, optimized team compositions, and mastery of advanced combat mechanics.
Achievers	Achievers enjoy mastering mechanics, completing objectives, and optimizing their performance. Punchline offers numerous progression systems that reward long-term engagement, including unlockable special attacks, L-Ink Combos, cosmetic items, achievements, Codex completion, hidden collectibles, and New Game Plus modifiers.
Explorers	Explorers enjoy discovering secrets and understanding every aspect of a game's world. Although Punchline is intentionally structured as a linear beat 'em up, each level contains optional routes, hidden collectibles, legendary costumes, secret cosmetic rewards, and environmental storytelling. The Codex further rewards exploration by gradually unlocking detailed information about characters, enemies, locations, and the world's lore as players progress through the adventure.

3.1.2 Gender demographic

According to the *Power of Play 2025* report, Action and Fighting games continue to attract a predominantly male audience. Globally, **53% of male players** report regularly playing Action games compared to **38% of female players**, while **38% of male players** regularly play Fighting games compared to **26% of female players**.



Although these figures suggest that Punchline is likely to attract a larger male audience, the game is **not designed for a specific gender**. Instead, its design philosophy focuses on cooperative gameplay, accessible mechanics, colorful visuals, and light-hearted social interaction, elements that appeal to a broad spectrum of players regardless of gender.

The same report also highlights that the global gaming population is now almost evenly split between **51% male** and **48% female** players, demonstrating that gaming has become a mainstream activity rather than one associated with a single demographic. This trend reinforces the decision to avoid gender-specific themes or aesthetics during Punchline's development.

3.1.3 Age demographic

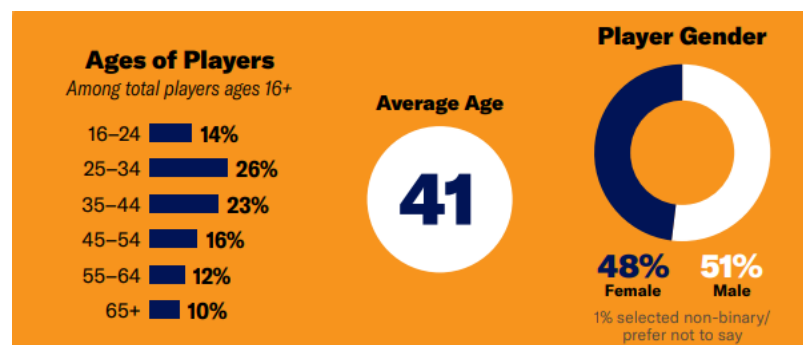
According to the *Power of Play 2025* report, the average age of video game players worldwide is **41 years old**, confirming that gaming has become a mainstream form of entertainment enjoyed well beyond younger audiences. The largest player demographic is represented by individuals aged **25-34**, followed closely by those aged **35-44**.

Punchline is primarily designed for this young adult and adult audience, particularly players who enjoy cooperative experiences with friends, siblings, partners, or family members.

The game's emphasis on local and online cooperative play also reflects the habits of these age groups, who often use games to maintain social connections despite geographical distance or busy schedules. The *Power of Play 2025* report highlights that many players view gaming as an

important means of spending quality time with friends and family, making cooperative titles increasingly attractive for adult audiences.

From a content perspective, Punchline intentionally avoids graphic violence, gore, and mature themes, making the experience appropriate for younger audiences while remaining engaging for adults. This approach supports a broad target audience beginning with the PEGI age rating applicable to fighting games (see [Section 4 - Legal Analysis](#)).



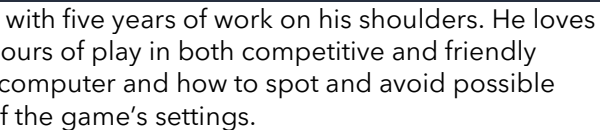
3.1.4 Geographic demographic

Punchline will initially be localized in **English** and **Italian**, making it immediately accessible to both the Italian market and the broad international audience that uses English as the primary language of communication within the gaming industry. Although the absence of additional localizations may initially limit accessibility in some regions, English remains the most widely adopted language on PC gaming platforms such as Steam, allowing the game to reach a significant portion of its potential audience.

To optimize development costs and reduce localization expenses, Punchline is planned for an initial release in **European markets**, with future localization and distribution in additional regions depending on the commercial performance of the game. Digital distribution through platforms such as Steam also simplifies expansion into new territories without requiring significant changes to the distribution pipeline.

From a cultural perspective, Punchline has been intentionally designed to appeal to an international audience. While its narrative is inspired by classic literature and fairy tales, the game avoids references tied to a specific country or culture. Instead, it presents universal themes such as friendship, cooperation, sacrifice, and adventure, making its story understandable and relatable across different markets.

3.1.5 Personas

Name	Federico	
Occupation	Student	
Location	Milan, Italy	
Age	29	
Expertise	High - this individual knows a lot about videogames and technology due to his previous work in tech company.	
Goal	Play an online game that is fun with his friends.	
Backstory	Federico is a computer science student with five years of work on his shoulders. He loves to hop online with his friends to enjoy hours of play in both competitive and friendly matches. Federico knows how to use a computer and how to spot and avoid possible problems that may arise during setup of the game's settings.	

Suitable for the game due to his passion for social games.

Name	Domenico
Occupation	Developer
Location	Salerno, Italy
Age	28
Expertise	High - this individual knows a lot about videogames and science in general thanks to his work in a tech company.
Goal	Play and discover all possible ways to advance in the game faster.
Backstory	Domenico is a computer science student with five years of work. He loves to discover all possible ways to break a game and move forward in the gameplay faster. He is a competitive person, born and raised as an athlete from his parents. Even if he is a very sociable person with a very keen sense of how to approach others, he decided to close and immerse himself in the videogame's worlds.



Not totally suitable for the game due to his desire to discovery.

Name	Anne
Occupation	Caregiver
Location	London, Great Britain
Age	56
Expertise	Low - this individual is not well versed with technology. She is mother of four children and works most of the time of day.
Goal	Enjoys fast and easy to learn games that allows her to occupy herself the evening.
Backstory	Anne is not from the digital era. She grew up reading books and going out with her friends. After a tragic break up with his ex-husband she decided to take care of her children by herself. Games like Candy Crush and Farmville are the way she can relax and not think for a short while.



Not suitable due to her responsibility and low time to spend playing.

Name	Mike	
Occupation	Professional fighter	
Location	Brooklyn, New York, USA	
Age	59	
Expertise	Low - as a professional fighter he is not involved with technologies. He knows what videogames are.	
Goal	Find a game with which he can relieve stress from work and his life.	
Backstory	Mike is not from the digital era. Since childhood he enjoyed fighting, losing himself in the adrenaline of a fight. He loves to read books and immerse himself in fantastic stories. Suitable for the game due to his work.	

3.2 Platform

The favorite device of choice of the players is the Mobile phone with an astounding 55% of the population of "The power of play" survey. Followed by the Computer/Laptop and Game console/handled with 21% each, Virtual reality with 2% and 1% for Other designated game hardware.

3.2.1 Target Platforms

In the following table all the platform with its respective **Priority**.

Name	Priority
Steam - PC	High
Others PC stores (Epic, Gog)	Medium
PlayStation 5	Medium
Xbox	Medium
Steam Deck / Handled	High
Nintendo Switch	High
Mobile phone	Low

3.2.2 Reasons

Steam and **Steam Deck**: thanks to its high user base it's the perfect platform to release to. It handles customer support and distribution with the standard 30% fee on the sale. The **steam deck** is an amazing piece of hardware that has revised the on-the-go formula allowing to run all the native windows games on Linux. Punchline's target audience—players looking for cooperative experiences with friends—matches Steam's strong community of indie action and co-op game enthusiasts. Steam also makes it easy for players to discover multiplayer games through recommendations, wishlists, and seasonal events.

PlayStation 5 and **Xbox**: These ninth-generation consoles represent a significant portion of the current gaming market and remain popular platforms for cooperative games played both online and locally. Punchline's emphasis on couch co-op, accessible gameplay, and controller-based combat fits naturally within the console ecosystem, where players frequently enjoy action games together from the same living room. Releasing on these platforms would allow the game to reach a broader audience while appealing to players who prefer cooperative experiences on dedicated gaming hardware.

Nintendo Switch: Nintendo's console has one of the largest install bases worldwide and is particularly associated with local multiplayer experiences. Its portable nature and emphasis on family-friendly and social games closely align with Punchline's cooperative gameplay philosophy. The game's colorful art style, non-violent presentation, and focus on teamwork make it particularly suitable for the Switch audience, which traditionally responds well to accessible multiplayer titles that can be enjoyed by players of different skill levels.

Mobile phone: Although the mobile gaming market has by far the largest user base, Punchline is not designed for touchscreen devices. Its combat system relies on precise movement, combo execution, coordinated L-Ink Combos, and simultaneous player interactions, making traditional mobile controls unsuitable without significant redesign. Additionally, the target audience for Punchline generally expects longer cooperative gameplay sessions using physical controllers rather than short mobile play sessions.

3.2.3 Launch strategies

The game will launch simultaneously on all the High and Medium priority platforms to maximize the user base.

This launch requires good infrastructure with a contingency plan to avoid problems and minimize the eventual servers' downtime (see Technical Design Document).

3.2.4 Cross-play e Cross-Save

The game will support the cross-play feature allowing friends from different platforms to play together, but it will not support a cross-save functionality as it requires more expenses to setup the required cloud infrastructure.

In the future it could be an amazing feature to add, as it could allow multiple copies to be bought from player that want to play from different platforms with same overall experience.

3.3 System requirements

The game requirements are based on market research of similar games with similar functionality and technologies.

3.3.1 Minimum

- **CPU:** Intel Core i5-6600K / AMD Ryzen 5 1600
- **GPU:** NVIDIA GTX 1060 (6GB) / RX 580 (or over)
- **RAM:** 8 GB
- **Network:** Broadband connection
- **Audio Card:** Yes
- **Operating System:** Windows 11

3.3.2 Recommended

- **CPU:** Intel Core i7-12700K / AMD Ryzen 7 5800X
- **GPU:** NVIDIA RTX 3070 / AMD RX 6800 (or over)
- **RAM:** 16 GB
- **Network:** Broadband connection
- **Audio Card:** Yes
- **Operating System:** Windows 11

3.4 Top performers

3.4.1 Street of Rage 4

Release date	30/04/2020
Base price	24,99 €
Developer	Dotemu
Publisher	Dotemu
Owner estimation	856.167
Steam DB Rating	90,33%
Metacritic	84
Open critic	84



Synopsis

Set ten years after the events of the original trilogy, Streets of Rage 4 sees Wood Oak City under the thumb of a new criminal empire led by the Y Twins (the children of the late Mr. X). They've used hypnotic music to corrupt the police and the populace. Legendary heroes Axel Stone and Blaze Fielding team up with a new generation—Cherry Hunter and Floyd Iraia—to punch their way through the neon-soaked streets and dismantle the Syndicate once and for all. It's a love letter to the 90s, wrapped in gorgeous hand-drawn art.

3.4.2 Absolum

Release date	09/10/2025
Base price	24,99 €
Developer	Dotemu
Publisher	Dotemu
Owner estimation	418.367
Steam DB Rating	89,86%
Metacritic	87
Open critic	86



Synopsis

In the dark fantasy realm of Talamh, the tyrannical Sun King Azra has enslaved the world's mages. Four outcast rebels, guided by the enchantress Uchawi, must fight through corrupted regions to stop Azra from awakening a primordial, interdimensional entity known as Absolum.

3.4.3 Sifu

Release date	08/02/2022
Base price	39,99 €
Developer	Sloclap
Publisher	Sloclap, Kepler Interactive
Owner estimation	1.539.700
Steam DB Rating	90,16%
Metacritic	81
Open critic	81



Synopsis

A classic revenge story. After witnessing the murder of your family by five martial arts masters, you spend eight years training in Pak Mei Kung Fu. Armed with a magical pendant that trades your lifespan for second chances, you have one single day to hunt down the assassins in a gritty, modern-day city.

3.4.4 Dead as Disco

This is the only title where the data are based on the demo/public test.

Release date	TBA
Base price	TBA
Developer	Brain Jar Games
Publisher	Brain Jar Games
Owner estimation	N/A
Steam DB Rating	94,49%
Metacritic	N/A
Open critic	N/A



Synopsis

Set in a hyper-stylized world where "silence is death," you play as a rebel fighter in a disco-themed dystopia. You must battle "vibe-killers"—enforcers of a regime that has banned music—using the power of rhythm to overthrow the silent overlords.

3.4.5 Castle Crasher

This is an older title, so remember the price must be calculated with inflation.

Release date	27/08/2008	
Base price	14,99 €	
Developer	The Behemoth	
Publisher	The Behemoth	
Owner estimation	12.206.667	
Steam DB Rating	94,87%	
Metacritic	83	
Open critic	78	

Synopsis

In a vibrant, chaotic medieval kingdom, a dark Wizard crashes a royal banquet, steals a large mystical crystal, and kidnaps four princesses. You play as one of the elemental Knights tasked by the King to embark on a globe-trotting crusade. From barbarian war camps and alien spaceships to volcanic caves, you must hack, slash, and blast your way through absurd enemies to rescue the princesses and recover the King's treasure. It is a satirical, high-energy adventure known for its iconic Behemoth art style and crude humor.

3.4.6 Hi-fi Rush

Release date	25/01/2023	
Base price	29,99 €	
Developer	Tango Gameworks	
Publisher	Bethesda Softworks (later Krafton)	
Owner estimation	1.400.000	
Steam DB Rating	95,09%	
Metacritic	87	
Open critic	89	

Synopsis

Chai, an optimistic slacker with a dream of becoming a rock star, undergoes a faulty medical procedure at Vandelay Technologies, a massive robotics corporation. The company accidentally fuses his personal music player to his chest, causing it to sync him perfectly to the beat of the world. Now labeled a "Defect" and hunted by Vandelay's security forces, Chai must fight through all six major departments of the corporation, from R&D to Marketing. Guided by a helpful robotic cat named 808 and a scrappy team of rebels, he aims to "un-break" himself and expose Vandelay's true, nefarious plan for absolute corporate control—all while rocking out to a killer soundtrack.

3.4.7 Scott Pilgrim EX

Release date	03/03/2026
Base price	19,99 €
Developer	Ubisoft Montreal, Ubisoft Chengdu
Publisher	Ubisoft
Owner estimation	22.300
Steam DB Rating	80,01%
Metacritic	74
Open critic	79



Synopsis

The game's story takes place after the cliffhanger ending of the Netflix series Scott Pilgrim Takes Off, with a prequel comic to the video game being released by O'Malley to promote the game.

In the year 20XX, Toronto has been affected by a gang war between vegans, demons, and robots. As the conflict rages, the other band members of Sex Bob-omb are kidnapped by a mysterious robotic doppelgänger of Scott Pilgrim (dubbed Metal Scott) while practicing for their gig. When Ramona finds Scott, she calls for backup from Roxie, Lucas, Matthew, Gideon, and Robot-01 to help them search the city and rescue Scott's band mates.

3.4.8 Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtle: Shredder's Revenge

Release date	16/06/2022
Base price	24,99 €
Developer	Tribute Games
Publisher	Dotemu
Owner estimation	672.467
Steam DB Rating	91,93%
Metacritic	85
Open critic	87



Synopsis

With Bebop and Rocksteady attacking Channel 6 to steal super-technological devices for Shredder and Krang's latest twisted plan, the Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles must leap into action. Across a series of iconic New York City locations—from the sewers and Manhattan to Dimension X—Leonardo, Michelangelo, Donatello, and Raphael are joined by Master Splinter, April O'Neil, and Casey Jones. Together, they must thwart the Foot Clan's attempt to rebuild the Statue of Liberty into a giant "Statue of Tyranny" and stop Shredder from executing his ultimate revenge.

3.4.9 Dynasty Warriors 9

Release date	13/02/2018
Base price	19,99 €
Developer	Omega Force
Publisher	Koei Tecmo
Owner estimation	415.233
Steam DB Rating	36,61%
Metacritic	65
Open critic	62



Synopsis

Set during the waning years of the Han Dynasty, *Dynasty Warriors 9* chronicles the epic "Romance of the Three Kingdoms" in a massive open-world reimagining of ancient China. As famine and rebellion (led by the Yellow Turbans) tear the country apart, legendary officers from the Wei, Wu, and Shu factions rise to power. Players follow the shifting tides of history—from the coalition against the tyrant Dong Zhuo to the eventual three-way struggle for unification—navigating political intrigue and massive battlefields to determine the fate of the land.

3.4.10 Devil May Cry 5

Release date	08/03/2019
Base price	29,99 €
Developer	Capcom
Publisher	Capcom
Owner estimation	5.826.667
Steam DB Rating	94,79%
Metacritic	87
Open critic	88



Synopsis

Several years after the events of Fortuna, a new demonic threat emerges in Red Grave City: a giant, blood-sucking tree known as the Qliphoth. When the legendary Devil Hunter Dante is defeated by the demonic king Urizen, it falls to the young Nero—whose demonic arm was recently stolen by a mysterious figure—and a cryptic newcomer named V to lead the counterattack. As the three warriors fight their way to the top of the tree, they uncover a shocking connection between V and Dante's twin brother, Vergil, leading to a high-stakes family reunion that will decide the fate of the human world.

3.5 Feature comparison

Game	Combat Style	Progression type	Unique Key Features	Focus
<i>Streets of Rage 4</i>	Classic Beat 'em up	Linear / Arcade	Rally System (Health recovery)	Urban Brawl
<i>Absolum</i>	Roguelite Brawler	Run-based / Meta	Inspiration Spells & Classes	Fantasy Strategy
<i>Sifu</i>	Hardcore Martial Arts	Age-based/Diegetic	Aging & Structure system	Skill Mastery
<i>Dead as Disco</i>	Rhythm Brawler	Track-based	Custom Music Integration	Musical Flow
<i>Castle Crashers</i>	Arcade RPG	Character Leveling	Animal Orbs & Magic	Party Chaos
<i>Hi-Fi Rush</i>	Rhythm Action	Mission-based	On-Beat Execution	Cinematic Style
<i>Scott Pilgrim EX</i>	Retro RPG Brawler	Shop-based Stats	Summoning Allies & Subspace	Pop Culture
<i>TMNT: Shredder's Re</i>	Modern Retro	Leveling / Story	Co-op Synergy (up to 6 players)	Team Synergy
<i>Dynasty Warriors 9</i>	Musou / Open World	Crafting / Narrative	Massive Scale (1 vs 1,000)	Warfare / Tactics
<i>Devil May Cry 5</i>	Stylistic Action	Ability Unlocks	Dynamic Music & Rank (S-SSS)	Pure Creativity
<i>Punchline: A literal adventure</i>	Classic Beat 'em up	Linear / Codex-based	Combo-based system between player attacks	User-friendliness, Skill mastery, Teamwork

3.6 Unique Selling Points

One of Punchline's strongest unique selling points is its **strong emphasis on true cooperative gameplay**. Unlike many multiplayer beat 'em ups, where players simply fight alongside each other while acting independently, Punchline is designed from the ground up to encourage constant communication and teamwork.

This philosophy is reflected in several core gameplay systems. The most distinctive is the **L-ink Combo** system, where specific abilities from different playable characters can be combined to unleash powerful cooperative attacks. These combinations require players to coordinate their timing and positioning, encouraging them to discuss strategies, plan their team composition, and master synergies between different heroes rather than relying solely on individual skill.

Cooperation also extends beyond combat. Throughout the adventure, players will encounter **environmental puzzles** specifically designed around teamwork. Rather than being simple obstacles, these puzzles require players to coordinate their actions, divide responsibilities, and communicate to progress. Some challenges ask players to defend teammates while they interact with objectives, while others require multiple players to manipulate heavy objects or activate mechanisms simultaneously (see the examples in section 5.2 Gameplay Description).

Another major feature is the game's **character customization**. Although each playable hero has a strong visual identity and a distinct role within the party, players can personalize their appearance through a wide variety of outfits, accessories, and special costumes inspired by classic fairy tales and literary works. Collecting new cosmetic items provides an additional incentive to explore optional paths and complete side objectives, while allowing every player to express their own style.

Customization is complemented by a rich **emote system**, particularly within the Van hub. Players can interact with the environment, perform contextual emotes, participate in small cooperative minigames, and simply spend time together between missions. These moments strengthen the social aspect of the game, making the Van feel like a living meeting place rather than just a menu.

Finally, the game aims to provide **high replayability**. Four playable characters, numerous L-Ink Combo combinations, unlockable cosmetics, achievements, optional collectibles, adjustable New Game Plus modifiers, and future expansions encourage players to revisit the adventure with different party compositions and strategies. Because each character fulfills a distinct role, changing even a single party member can significantly alter both combat dynamics and cooperative interactions, making every playthrough feel fresh.

4. Legal Analysis

4.1 Hardware and Software

4.1.1 Trademarks

Wandering Strangers™ is the name of the game studio. On *TMView* the web application for the *European Trademark and Design Network*, the name is available for registration.

4.1.2 Copyright

Punchline: A literal adventure™ is a new **IP** (*Intellectual Property*) of the **Wandering Strangers** independent game studio.

All the assets in the game have been purchased/downloaded from official stores and with permissions to be used in commercial projects.

4.1.3 Third Party Licenses

Unity Engine® is the engine of choice for this game. We do not detain the ownership of the brand or of the software released for free. We do not own any of the third parties used by Unity Engine, if any.

4.2 Game rating



Due to the absent gore elements and the mild violence depiction the game is in line with the **Everyone** and **PEGI 7** classification.

ESRB - Everyone: Content is generally suitable for all ages. May contain minimal cartoon, fantasy or mild violence and/or infrequent use of mild language.

PEGI 7: The content of games with a PEGI 3 rating is considered suitable for all age groups. The game should not contain any sounds or pictures that are likely to frighten young children. A very mild form of violence (in a comical context or a childlike setting) is acceptable. No bad language should be heard.

For more details look the homepages of the rating groups: [PEGI](https://www.esrb.org/) and [ESRB](https://www.pegi.info/).

5. Gameplay

5.1 Overview

Punchline: A Literal Adventure is a top-down 3D cooperative beat 'em up for 2 to 4 players focused on accessibility, and team synergy. Players take control of members of the Four Wheels Book Club, empowered by literary heroes, and fight together against hordes of ink-born enemies across story-themed levels.

5.2 Gameplay description

The core gameplay loop is based on entering an encounter, defeating waves of enemies, moving to the next area, and repeating this structure until the end of the level is reached. Sometimes the players must solve puzzles to advance in the level.

While the controls are designed to be simple and readable, the game gains depth through shared combos, complementary character roles, and coordinated use of abilities between players.

Each playable character channels powers inspired by iconic literary heroes and contributes differently to combat, encouraging players to experiment with team compositions and synergistic strategies. The overall goal is to create a cooperative experience that is easy to pick up, satisfying to master, and strongly centered on action, re-playability, and social play.

5.2.1 In the levels

Each level is structured as a sequence of combat areas in which players must defeat groups of enemies to progress. As the team advances, encounters become more demanding and require better coordination, use of character abilities, and effective crowd control, until the level culminates in a final, more difficult encounter, or in special levels, in a boss fight.

Resources

- **Health:** Each player has a fixed amount of health that represents their survivability during combat. Taking damage reduces this value, and when it reaches zero, the character is temporarily defeated and transformed into an ink-corrupted enemy. Managing health and avoiding unnecessary damage is crucial, especially since repeated knockdowns make recovery progressively harder.
- **Inspiration Points:** During combat, players generate Inspiration Points by dealing damage to enemies or collecting power-ups dropped during encounters.
- **Collectibles:** These items can unlock new cosmetic options such as outfits, accessories, or emotes, allowing players to further personalize their characters and enhance the social aspect of the game.
- **Power-Ups:** Occasionally dropped by enemies or found within levels, power-ups provide temporary advantages by restoring health, or gaining additional Inspiration points. They encourage players to stay engaged with the battlefield and adapt to dynamic situations.

Combat System

The combat system of *Punchline* builds on the core principles of classic beat 'em ups, reinterpreted through a strong cooperative focus to deliver an experience that is both accessible and mechanically engaging.

Players face waves of enemies through melee attacks, medium distance attacks, special abilities and defensive options. The controls are designed to be intuitive from the very beginning, allowing casual players to quickly engage with the game, while still providing depth for those who seek to master its mechanics over time.

At the core of the system are **combos**, which allow players to chain basic attacks and abilities together. Each character features a unique move set inspired by a literary hero (see [section 6.1 Playable Characters](#)) and their role within the team.

A key element is **space control**. Players must position themselves to avoid being surrounded, using area-of-effect attacks, knockback, and movement to manage the battlefield.

The defensive action uses the same input for all characters, but its effect changes depending on the archetype. For example, Tank characters perform a parry, while agile characters make a quick roll. It allows the player to quickly avoid incoming attacks and reposition during combat. Enemy attacks are telegraphed, so the players can react in time.

Mechanics such as reviving fallen teammates coming back as Ink-monsters and the inclusion of environmental puzzles further reinforce cooperative gameplay.

L-Ink Combo System

At the heart of the combat lies the L-Ink Combo system, centered on the **Inspiration Meter**, a personal resource recharged by accumulating **Inspiration Points**.

- **Inspiration Points** are earned every time a player lands a successful hit on an enemy.
- The Inspiration Meter is divided into sections, each one filled by several **Inspiration Points**.

The inspiration points are the key to using the L-Ink Combos, powerful shared combos, that combine the effects of the combos of two players in one, devastating attack (for examples of L-Ink Combos, see [section 6.1.5 L-Ink Combo Examples](#)).

For example, the **Tank** archetype (see section [5.2.4 Character Archetypes](#)) can execute a powerful strike that generates a forward-moving vortex, while the **Support** character can launch a small fireball. If the Tank Vortex encounters the Mage's Healing Fireball and the Tank has enough notches of his Inspiration meter full, the attack transforms into a **Fire Tornado**. If the Tank Inspiration meter is not full enough, the two attacks simply don't converge.

This system encourages players to communicate actively during combat, coordinating their timing, positioning, and ability usage. To prevent "infinite loops" and keep the focus on core gameplay, **L-Ink combos do not generate additional Inspiration Points**.

This ensures the meter is primarily fueled through basic combat, keeping standard attacks and constant pressure on enemies central to the experience. Consequently, the combo system rewards not just individual efficiency, but the group's ability to create **synergy** between different characters.

Communication becomes a fundamental pillar of the experience, as the most effective combinations arise from coordination rather than isolated execution.

L-Ink Combo: Fire Tornado

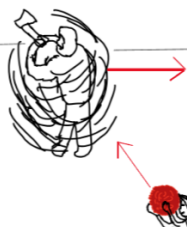
Storyboard explaining how a L-Ink Combo works

During a wave encounter, the Tank player and the Support player decide to use a L-Ink Combo!

Players' combo



Now, simply aim!



Inspiration Bar requirement



L-Ink Combo successful!



The Tank player and the Support player starts to execute their individual combos. The Tank uses the attack to generate the Vortex attack (For example A->A->B), while the Support player uses the attack to generate the Fireball (For example A->A->A->B).

The Two players synchronized with a good result, and the Support player simply aims the fireball towards the Tank.

If the two attacks collide and the Tank has enough notches of his inspiration bar, the two attacks will fuse in a L-Ink Combo! (that is the case, because the Fire Tornado requires two notches).

The two attack collided, unleashing a powerful Fire Tornado, that emits small fireballs in all directions!

Puzzles

During levels, players will also encounter **environmental puzzles** that must be solved to progress. Most of these puzzles involve interacting with the environment to open blocked paths or create accessible routes forward.

For example, players may be required to pull a large lever to open a closed gate, a task that takes time to complete. By holding the interaction button, a character becomes engaged in operating the mechanism. Multiple players can work on the same lever, and the more players participate, the faster the gate opens.

However, as soon as the first player begins interacting with the lever, waves of enemies start spawning and attacking the group, including those focused on the objective. If a player operating the lever is hit, they are forced to release it. If no players are interacting with the lever, the gate immediately closes.

Enemy waves stop only when the gate is either fully opened or completely closed. This creates a dynamic scenario where players must coordinate effectively, balancing offense and defense by protecting teammates while progressing the objective.

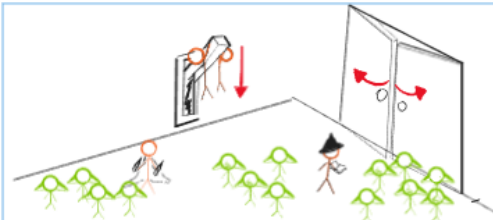
Cooperative Puzzle: Pulling lever to open gate

The players approach the lever



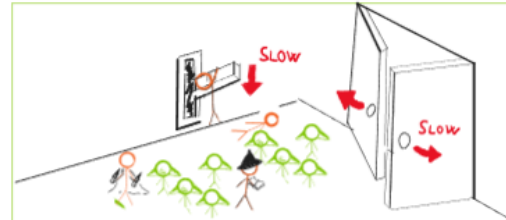
Players understand that the lever might open the gate, and that the lever is interactable.

Two players begin to pull the lever



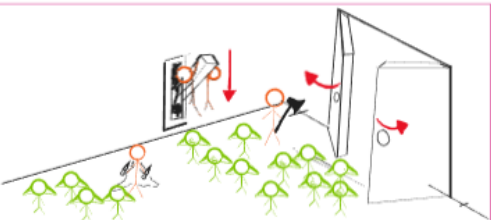
Two players start pulling the lever, while the other two defend their friends.

A player is hit



While fighting, the two players let a monster through, and it hits one of the player. The gate now opens more slowly.

Another player takes its place



A player promptly switches with the fallen one, now the gate opens again at a normal rate.

The players open the gate



The gate is now fully open. The players attached to the lever automatically dismount and the gate remains open. There are some monster left on screen, but no new one arrives.

The road is now free!



The gate is open, all the leftover monsters are slain, so the party can venture forth!

In another scenario, players may need to overcome an obstacle such as a wall too high to jump over. Nearby, there may be crates that can be arranged to form a climbable structure. Some of these crates are too heavy to move alone and require multiple players to push them. Heavy crates will only move if all players pushing them apply force in the same direction, encouraging communication and coordination.

The core idea behind these puzzles is to actively promote cooperation beyond combat. Players are encouraged to communicate, plan, and coordinate their actions in real time, facing challenges that require teamwork in ways that go beyond simply defeating enemies.

Reviving Fallen Teammates

When a character's health reaches zero, they collapse to the ground and are engulfed by ink, transforming into an enemy. When this happens, the player controlling that character loses control, and the character begins attacking their teammates.

This ink-corrupted version is relatively weak and can be defeated with a few hits, freeing the character and bringing them back into the game. However, the monster's health gradually increases with each time the character is defeated during the level, making repeated knockdowns increasingly dangerous, still ensuring that the players don't get frustrated and can come back in action as soon as possible.

Bosses and Elité enemies

In **Punchline**, both boss fights ([see Section 6.2 NPCs](#) for details on bosses and their encounters) and elite enemies will be present. Boss fights are designed with dedicated mechanics and unique levels built specifically around them.

Elite enemies, on the other hand, are enhanced variants of standard enemies, slightly stronger or equipped with modified mechanics compared to their base versions and distinguished by a colour swap. They will not appear in every level but serve as a valuable tool to introduce variety and keep the gameplay experience dynamic.

5.2.2 The Van

Interaction with the Environment

Inside the Van, players can interact with various elements of the surrounding environment. Each interaction allows players to trigger a set of context-specific emotes tied to that area, creating opportunities to relax, unwind, and engage with one another in a more social and light-hearted way.

These interactions are designed to reinforce the game's focus on social play, offering moments of downtime between missions.

Examples of these interactions can be found in the Van Level Diagram ([see section 5.5.1 Van](#)), showcasing different areas where players can perform unique actions, participate in small minigames, or simply enjoy shared moments together.

The Wardrobe

The Wardrobe is the area of the Van where players can customize their character's appearance. By interacting with Victoria ([see section 6.2 NPCs](#)), players can access the customization menu to change outfits and accessories.

Clothing pieces can be obtained by completing levels, progressing through the story, or discovering hidden book pages placed in optional paths or hard-to-reach areas within levels. This encourages exploration and rewards players who take the time to fully engage with each environment.

Outfits are divided into three categories: head, upper body, and lower body. Players can freely mix and match items within these categories to create their preferred look.

In addition, there are special outfits that override all three categories at once. These rare sets are typically inspired by fairy tales and classic stories, offering more distinctive and thematic designs, while standard outfit pieces are not necessarily tied to specific literary references.

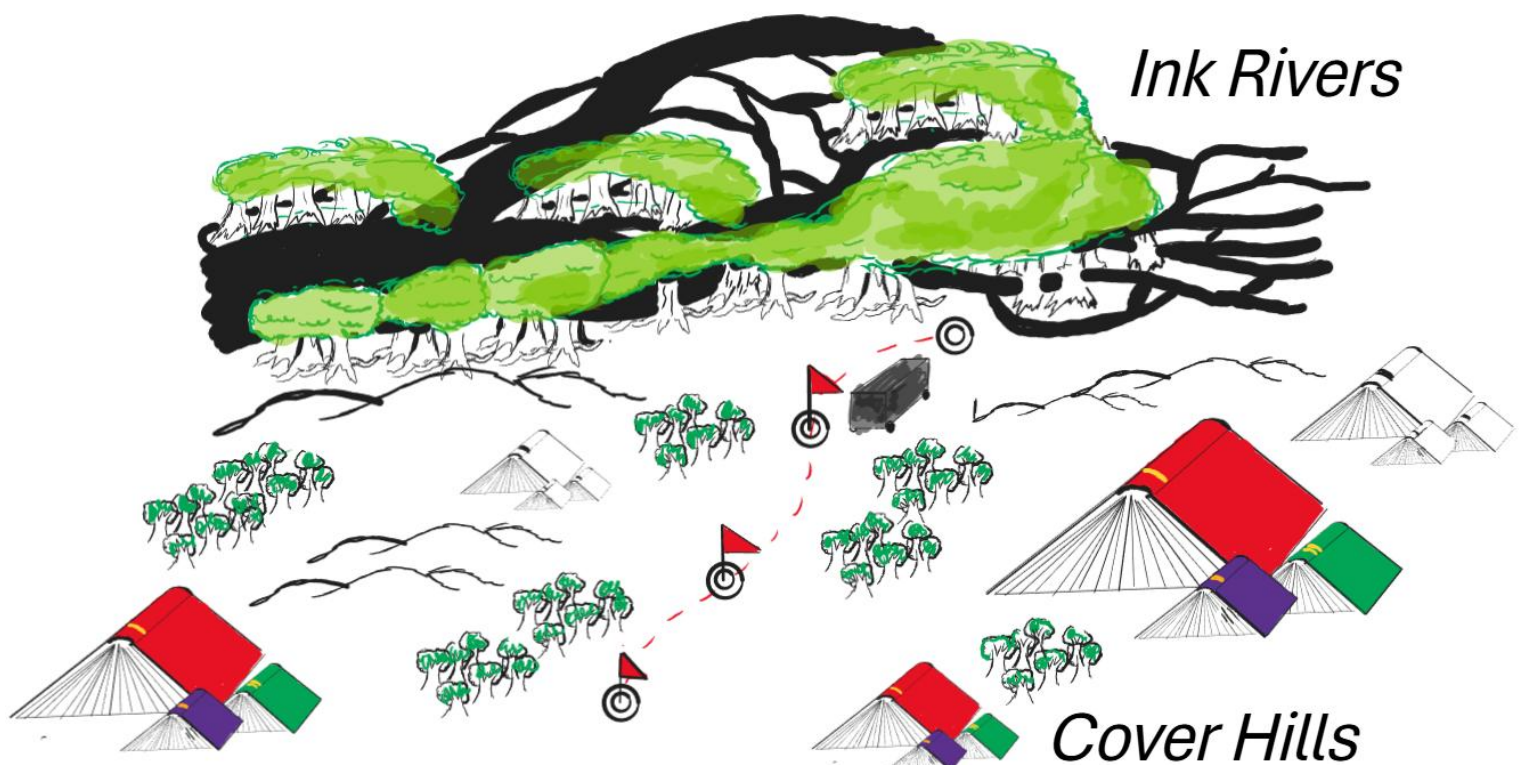
5.2.3 The World Map

On the world map, the player who interacted with Old Gary ([see section 6.2 NPCs](#)) takes control of the Van and can freely drive it across the map, exploring the available areas. Circular nodes represent playable levels, and interacting with one of them allows the player to start the corresponding stage.

Each node once selected displays useful information, such as the level name, and whether it has already been completed. Some nodes may also include additional indicators, such as number of collectibles.

The path between nodes guide players toward the next objective, while previously completed levels remain accessible for replay, and are signaled by a flag. This allows players to revisit earlier stages to improve performance or find the missing collectibles.

While one player controls the Van, the rest of the team remains involved by observing the map and coordinating the next destination, reinforcing the social aspect of decision-making. As players advance through the game, new areas of the map gradually unlock.



CONCEPT ART FOR THE WORLD MAP

5.2.4 Character Archetypes

Punchline is designed for four primary playable archetypes, each offering a distinct combat role and playstyle. Their identity, story and attacks are explained in [section 6.1 Playable Characters](#). This reinforces the game's cooperative identity and allows players to contribute to the team in diverse ways:

- **The Tank:** A large, resilient fighter with high HP. This archetype features slow attacks but high damage per hit, making them ideal for holding the front line and exerting direct pressure on enemies.
- **The Speedster:** A fast female character specializing in agility and attack frequency. While dealing lower damage per individual hit, she compensates with high mobility and rapid successive attacks, allowing her to reposition easily and charge the combo meter efficiently.
- **The Balanced:** A middle ground between speed and strength. This character offers moderate damage, average mobility, and a more versatile playstyle.
- **The Support:** A low-HP character whose defining trait is the ability to generate a **healing area** for nearby allies when certain combos are executed. This transforms combo usage into both an offensive and defensive tool.

5.3 Controls

5.3.1 In Game Controls

Command	Keyboard	Xbox Controller (Xbox)	Dualsense Controller (PlayStation)	Joy-Cons (Nintendo)
Move Up	W	Left Stick Up	Left Stick Up	Left Stick Up
Move Left	A	Left Stick Left	Left Stick Left	Left Stick Left
Move Down	S	Left Stick Down	Left Stick Down	Left Stick Down
Move Right	D	Left Stick Right	Left Stick Right	Left Stick Right
Basic Attack/Interact	J	X	Square	Y
Special Attack	K	Y	Triangle	X
Evade/Block	L	Left Trigger	L2	ZL
Pause Menu	Esc	Start	Start	Plus
Jump	Spacebar	A	Cross	B
Open Emote Wheel	Tab	Right stick click	Right stick click	Right stick click
Select Emote	Key 1 to 8	Right stick	Right stick	Right stick

5.3.2 UI Controls

Command	Keyboard	Xbox Controller (Xbox)	Dualsense Controller (PlayStation)	Joy-Cons (Nintendo)
Navigate menu	W, S	Left Stick Up, Left Stick Down	Left Stick Up, Left Stick Down	Left Stick Up, Left Stick Down
Confirm	J	X	Square	Y
Back	Esc	B	Circle	A

Character movement is handled through the WASD keys on keyboard and the left analog stick on the controller.

The character automatically faces the direction of movement. On keyboard, the facing direction depends on the movement input given through the WASD keys. On controller, the character faces the direction in which the player is moving through the left stick.

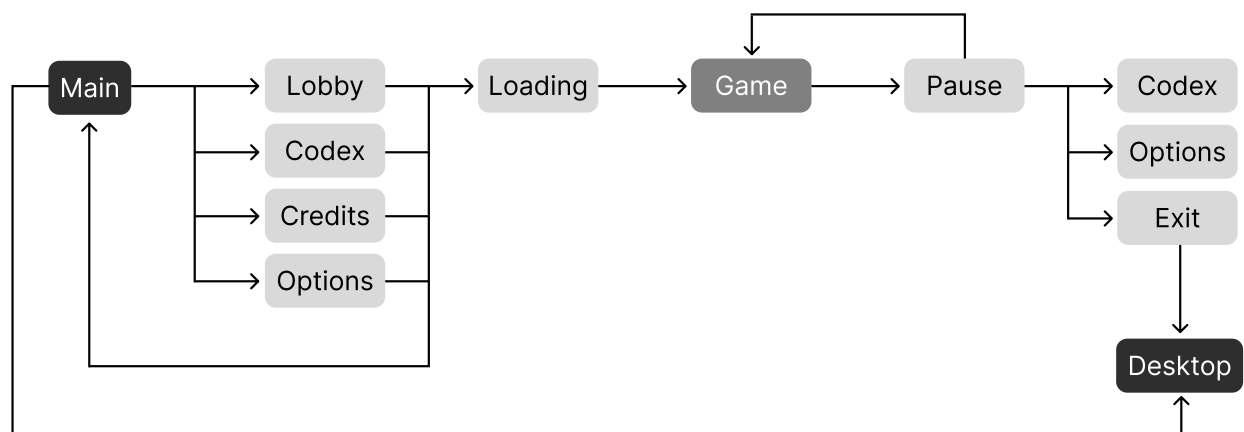
In multiplayer sessions, pausing affects the entire match, and only the player who initiated the pause can resume the game.

All playable characters share the same control layout.

5.3.3 Interfaces

In this section will be showcased all the Mocks for the UI. They are high-level drafts to bootstrap the development and allow the artist to start working on the final one.

Flowchart



This is the flowchart that represents all the possible interaction with the UI with the resulting navigation.

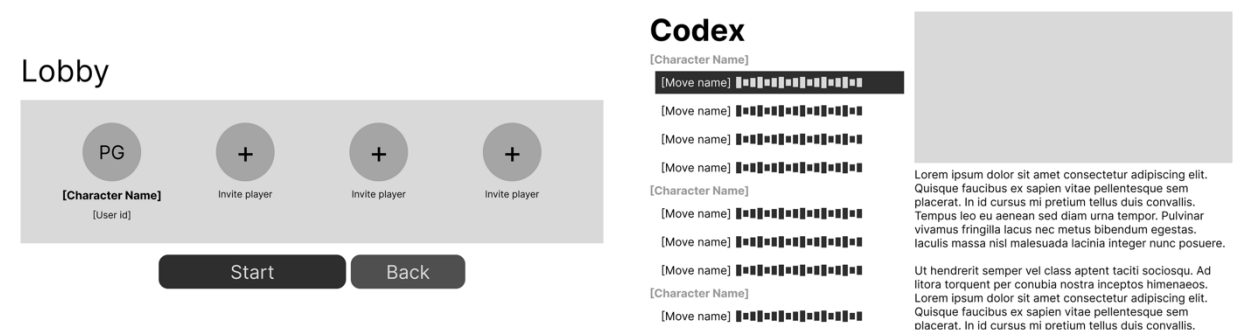
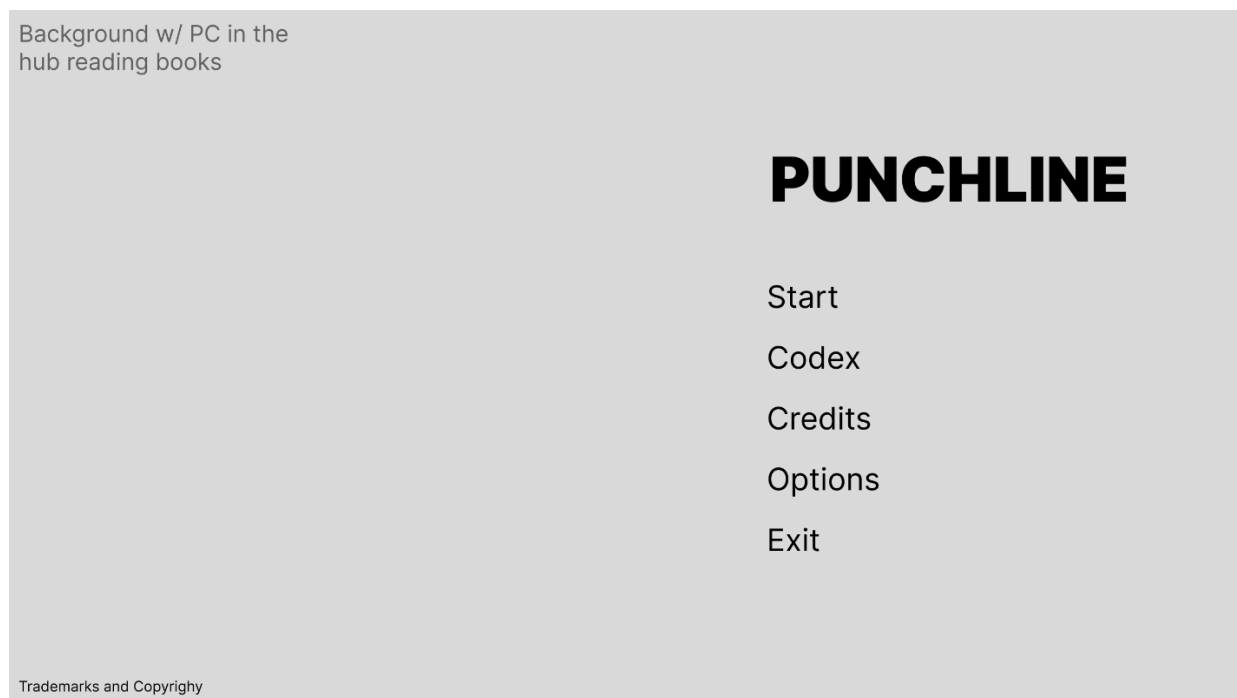
Main menu

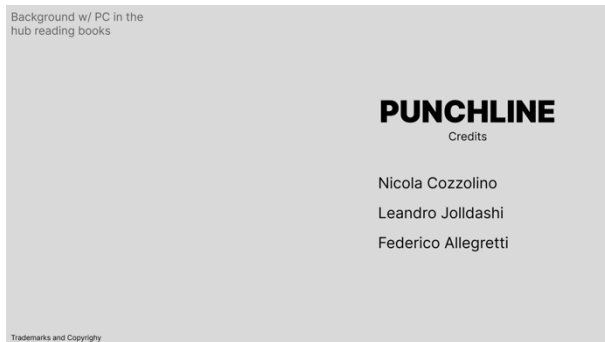
When booting up the game the user is presented with this UI. The main components are:

- Menu entries on the right
- A scene with PCs reading books in the background

From this page the user can navigate to:

- **Lobby:** clicking on the start button the user navigates to the lobby, where he can invite his friend to the party. The maximum number of players that can play is 4.
- **Codex:** by clicking on the Codex button he can review and study all the move sets that have been found during the gameplay.
- **Credits:** by clicking on the Credits button, it can see all the people that worked on the project.
- **Options:** by clicking on the Options button he can navigate and modify all the possible game settings as he prefers.
- **Exit:** clicking on the exit button the game closes.





Options

Graphic Settings

[Entry]

[Entry]

Accessibility

[Entry]

[Entry]

[Entry]

[Entry]

[Entry]

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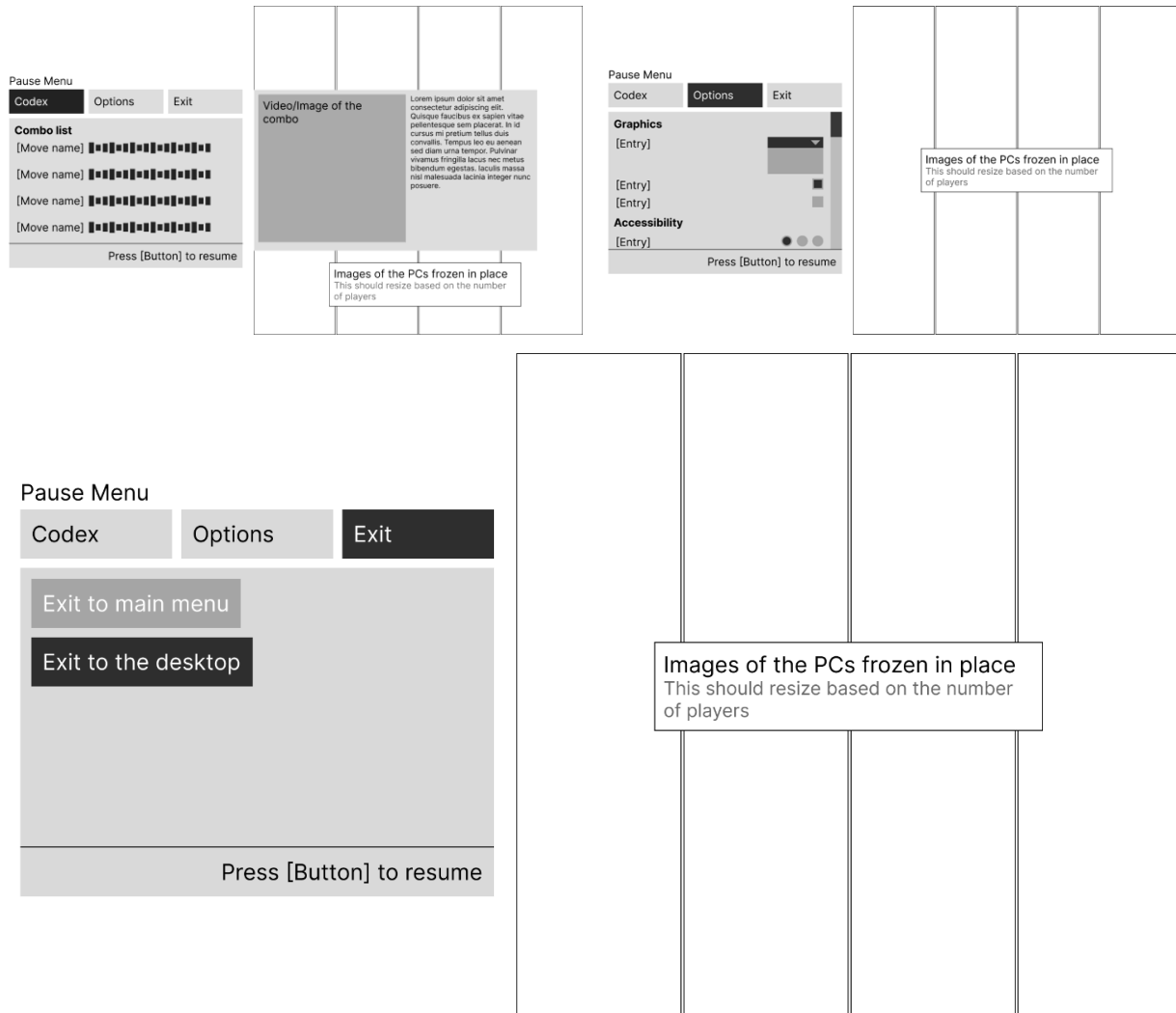
In-game HUD



In-game the player can keep, his and of the others, health bar and inspiration bar. The UI is simple and comprised of:

- **Character name**
- **Health bar**
- **Inspiration bar**

Pause menu



Each player can pause the game. When pause a menu with three sections will appear. These sections are:

- **Codex:** allows the players can check all the character combos
- **Options:** allow the players to check all the possible options of the game.
- **Exit:** allows the player to quit to the main menu or the desktop.

Loading screen

Background w/ a picture
representing the loading
scene/level

PUNCHLINE

[Level name]

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consectetur
adipiscing elit. Quisque faucibus ex sapien
vitae pellentesque sem placerat. In id cursus
mi pretium tellus dui convallis.

Trademarks and Copyrighty

During loading time, the player will see a simple screen with basics information on the level (name and description) and a background image of the level.

NPC interaction popups

Game Scene

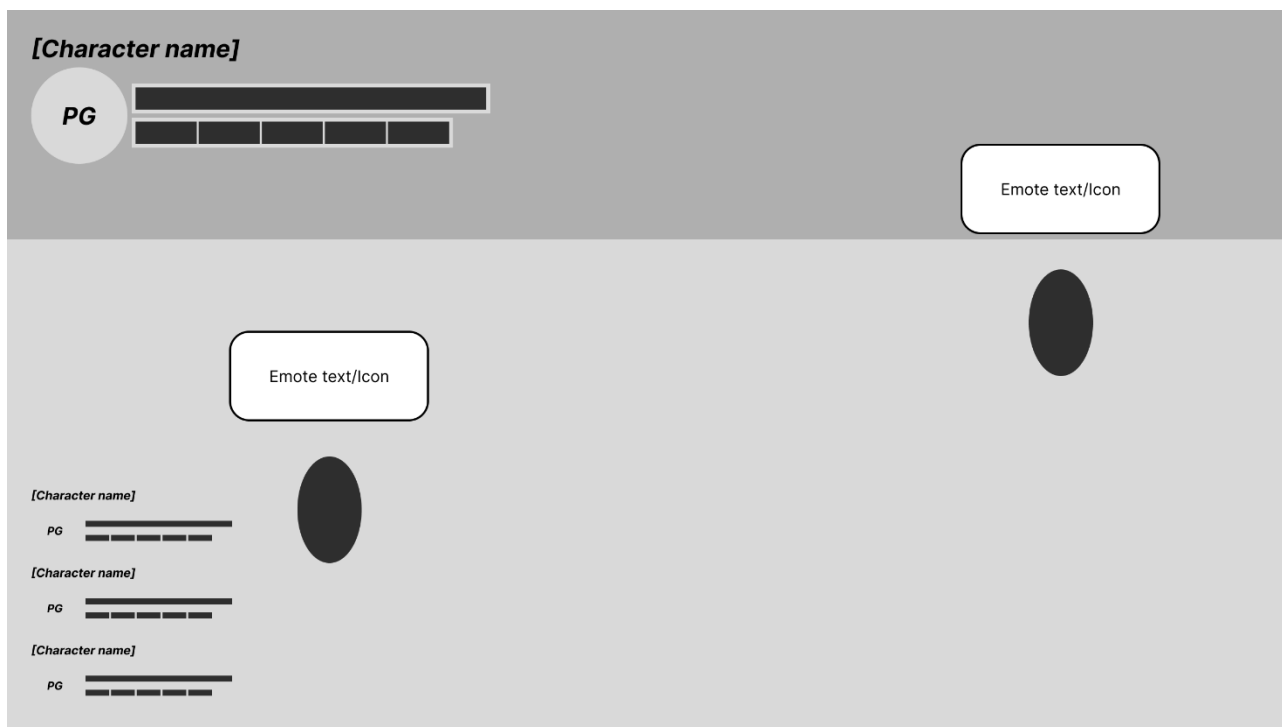
[NPC name]

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consectetur adipiscing elit. Quisque faucibus ex sapien vitae pellentesque sem placerat. In id cursus mi pretium tellus dui convallis.



When interacting with NPC a dialogue will appear. This dialogue will allow the player to read what the NPC has to say.

Players emotes' popups



During fights and in the hub, the player can chat with each other using emotes that can express emotions (through in-game emoji) or simple predefined messages.

5.4 Rules

- Players progress through each level by defeating all enemies in the current combat area. A new area becomes accessible only after the room has been completely cleared.
- Each playable character has a unique moveset composed of basic combos, special attacks, and exclusive L-Ink Combo interactions with other characters.
- Basic attacks can be chained into increasingly powerful combo strings, ending with unique finishers that vary depending on the input sequence.
- Special attacks consume Inspiration Points, with stronger abilities requiring a larger amount of Inspiration.
- Each player has an individual Inspiration Bar that is filled by damaging enemies and collecting Inspiration orbs dropped during combat.
- L-Ink Combos are activated when specific special abilities from two different players interact with one another. These cooperative attacks consume Inspiration and produce unique effects that are significantly stronger than the original abilities.
- Friendly fire is disabled, allowing players to fight aggressively without damaging teammates.
- Players can freely revive downed allies during combat, making positioning and teamwork essential during difficult encounters.
- Each playable character can sustain multiple hits before being knocked down. When a character is knocked down, they become covered in ink and temporarily transform into an Ink Monster hostile to the remaining players.
- While transformed, the affected player loses control of their character until teammates defeat the Ink Monster by attacking it several times.
- The health of a transformed Ink Monster increases with each time that player is defeated during the current level, making repeated knockdowns progressively more dangerous.
- If all players are knocked down simultaneously, the encounter is lost and the team restarts from the latest checkpoint.
- Checkpoints are generally placed at the beginning of each level and immediately before boss encounters.
- Combat is built around three core defensive and offensive actions: Basic Attack, Special Attack, and Dodge (or Block, depending on the character).
- Dodges provide brief invulnerability frames.
- Most enemies telegraph powerful attacks through clear visual cues, allowing attentive players to react appropriately.
- Elite enemies introduce unique mechanics and behaviours that distinguish them from their standard counterparts.
- Boss encounters feature exclusive mechanics that require players to adapt their strategy rather than relying solely on combat efficiency.
- Environmental puzzles are integrated into the gameplay loop and often require two or more players to cooperate by interacting with mechanisms, moving heavy objects, or defending teammates while they complete objectives.
- Some interactive objects require multiple players to operate simultaneously, reducing interaction time proportionally to the number of cooperating players.
- Cosmetic customization does not provide gameplay advantages and is entirely optional.
- Players may freely switch outfits and accessories while inside the Van hub between missions.
- Level progression depends on fully clearing each combat encounter. This rule also applies to boss access, since players must eliminate all enemies in an area before moving on.

5.5 Scoring and winning conditions

Punchline: A Literal Adventure is primarily structured around cooperative level completion rather than a traditional arcade scoring system.

In the current main play mode, players win by completing the level. A level is considered completed when the team clears all required combat rooms, overcomes any mandatory progression obstacles, and defeats the final wave of the stage or the boss.

Each combat room is completed only when all enemies in the encounter have been defeated. Players cannot access the next area until the current room has been fully cleared. The team loses the current encounter if all playable characters are simultaneously knocked down and no one is left able to recover the others. When this happens, the game restarts from the latest checkpoint.

Checkpoints are generally placed at the beginning of a level or before boss and elite encounters. This structure reduces frustration while preserving the tension of cooperative combat. Player performance is measured through progression, successful room clears, team survival, and completion of the level.

5.6 Disconnections

If a player loses connection to the game due to network issues, two possible scenarios can occur:

- **If the disconnected player is the host**, all players currently in the session are returned to the main menu, regardless of the current state of the game. If players were inside a level at the time of disconnection, their progress will be preserved up to the last reached checkpoint. If no checkpoint has been reached, the level will restart from the beginning upon re-entry.
- **If the disconnected player is not the host** and the group is either inside a level or within the Van/world map, the game will be paused. The host is then given the option to either continue the level without the disconnected player or wait for them to reconnect. If the connection is restored, the session resumes normally from the paused state.

In all cases, the player who reconnects must be the same individual who disconnected; account swapping or player replacement during reconnection is not allowed. During this reconnection phase, it is not possible to add new players to the session. New players may only join again by continuing the game normally and returning to the Van, where standard joining rules apply.

5.7 Modes and other features

5.7.1 Punchline: A Literal Adventure Main Story

The main story of Punchline is designed to be played by 2 to 4 players, either in local or online co-op.

After completing the Prologue (described in [section 7.2.1 Introduction](#)), players can begin progressing through the levels, completing them one by one. This mode represents the core experience of the game, allowing players to explore the world of Punchline and uncover its story.

5.7.2 Codex

The Codex is a section of the pause menu that contains useful information about characters, NPCs, and enemies ([see section 5.3.3 Interfaces](#)).

In the **Characters** section, players can find a short synopsis describing the backstory of each main character, along with a list of available combos and L-Ink Combos for that character ([see section 6.1 Playable Characters](#)).

In the **NPCs** section, players can access information about the main story NPCs, including their background and their role within the game ([see section 6.2 NPCs](#)).

In the **Monsters** section, players can find useful details about encountered enemies, such as their observed attacks and the areas of the world where they are most found.

In the **Facts** section, players are provided with a summary of the story up to the current point, including the main objective, as well as additional, non-essential lore such as the backstory ([see section 7.3 Backstory](#)).

The Codex is designed as a non-central feature of the experience, intended for players who are more interested in narrative elements, even though they are not the primary target audience of Punchline. Completing the Codex in its entirety is also required to unlock an achievement ([see section 5.4.5 Achievements](#)).

5.7.3 New Game Plus

After completing the game for the first time, players seeking a more intense challenge can access New Game Plus.

This mode allows players to modify various gameplay parameters, such as enemy health, damage, and speed, as well as adjust certain rules, including the presence of checkpoints and the revival mechanic. These options enable players to tailor the experience to their preferred level of difficulty, particularly appealing to those who enjoy more demanding and skill-based challenges.

5.7.4 DLCs

After the release of the game, two major paid expansions are planned, spaced appropriately over time. These expansions will introduce new playable content, characters, and customization options, helping to keep the player base engaged after the launch of the main game. The two expansions are titled **Punchline: The Book of the Endless Tower** and **Punchline: The Book of the Ancient War**.

Punchline: The Book of the Endless Tower

In this expansion, which becomes accessible at a certain point during the main story once downloaded, players will be introduced to a new area, **the Endless Tower**, along with a side story, new outfits, and a new playable character.

The Endless Tower is an incredibly tall structure that stretches toward the sky. Players must face consecutive waves of enemies as they attempt to climb to the top. The difficulty of each encounter gradually increases, combining enemies from across the base game with new, exclusive foes unique to this area. The area will feature few checkpoints, posing a greater challenge to the players than the main story.

As players advance, they will be able to unlock Old Gary's outfit, as Old Gary himself as a playable character also for the main story.

Synopsis

After returning to the Van from yet another grueling battle, Old Gary approaches the members of the Four Wheels Book Club:

"Kids, I might've found something interesting while you were out."

Gary then leads the party to the base of a mysterious tower, one that seems to stretch endlessly into the sky, its peak lost beyond the clouds.

Punchline: The Book of the Ancient War

In this expansion, set after the events of the main game, Aria ([see section 6.2 NPCs](#)) calls upon the entire Four Wheels Book Club for a new mission. An ancient evil has discovered a powerful artifact capable of manipulating time, intending to escape the ancient war and reshape history to conquer the world and enslave it, obtaining vengeance for what the humans did in ancient times ([see section 7.3 Backstory](#)).

Throughout this expansion, players will travel between the present and the past, facing new levels and challenges as they attempt to stop Sylas, the Lord of War, from carrying out his plan. Each area presents unique environments and new enemies, gradually revealing the origins of the conflict and the true scale of the threat.

Joining the original cast is Albert, now redeemed and returned as the leader of the Club. He also becomes a playable character available from the beginning of the expansion. Players will also be able to use him in a New Game Plus mode after completing the expansion.

The expansion introduces new outfits for Albert and the rest of the group, further expanding customization options.

Synopsis

When a powerful artifact capable of bending time falls into the hands of **Sylas, the Lord of War**, history itself is thrown into jeopardy. Determined to rewrite the past and claim dominion over the world, Sylas seeks to escape the ancient war that once shaped the fate of magic and humanity.

Guided by Aria, the Four Wheels Book Club embarks on a perilous journey across time, regaining their powers to venture between past and present to stop him. Along the way, they uncover long-buried truths about the ancient conflict and the origins of the world they thought they knew.

With Albert now redeemed and fighting alongside them, the group must confront both the echoes of history and the consequences of their own past actions, before time itself is irreversibly broken.

5.7.5 Achievements

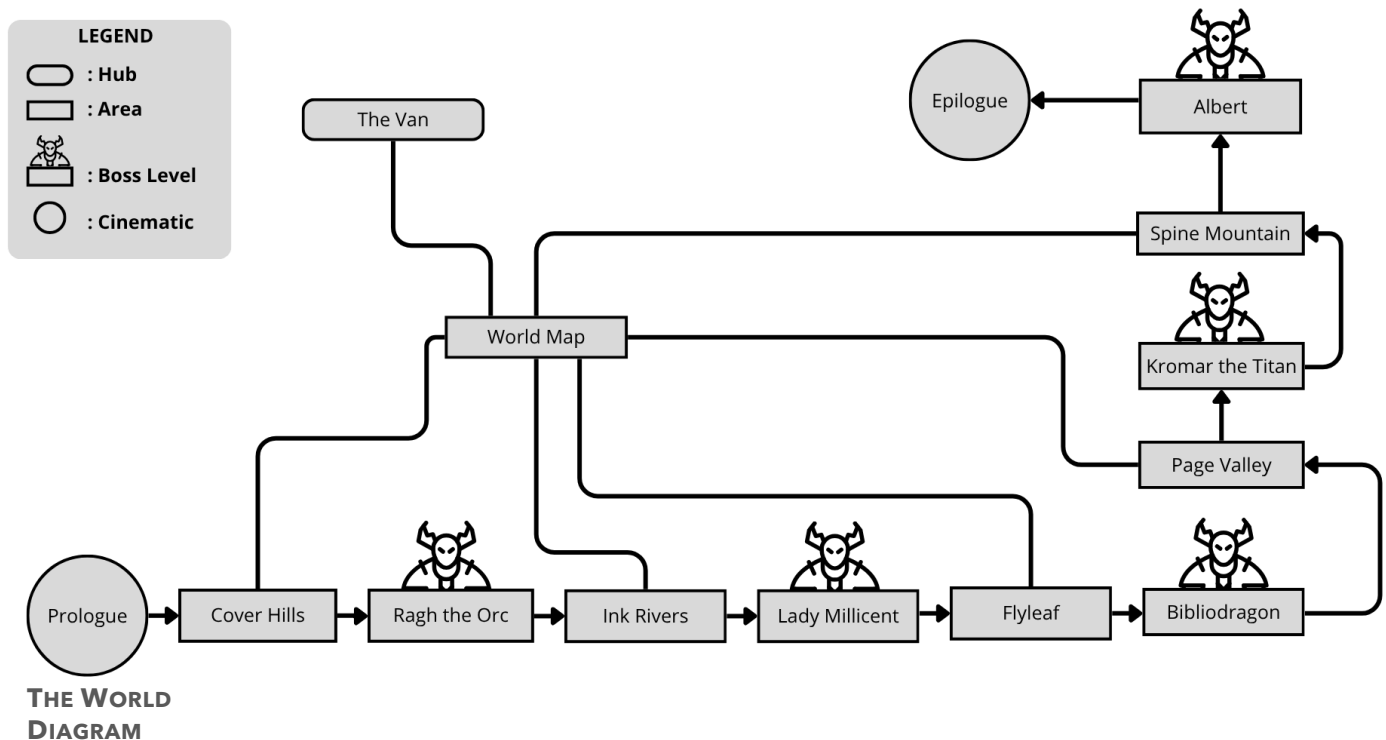
Given the release on platforms such as Steam, players will be able to unlock achievements during the game. Below a list of achievement names and their descriptions.

Name	Description
New Beginnings	Complete the prologue.
Test of Strength	Defeat Ragh and complete the Cover Hills.
Bending Space	Defeat Millicent and complete the Ink Rivers.
Clipping the Wings	Defeat the Bibliodragon and complete Flyleaf.
Where's the Castle?	Defeat Kromar and leave Page Valley.
A Literal Adventure	Defeat Albert and complete the game.
Cooperative Power	Perform an L-Ink Combo.
Cooperative Mastery	Perform 50 L-Ink Combos.
Cooperative Dominance	Perform 100 L-Ink Combos.
Runway Ready	Find your first outfit piece.
Fashion Expert	Find 10 outfit pieces.
Fashion Hero	Find all outfit pieces.
Sticky Situation	Turn into an ink monster 10 times.
Unbreakable Bond	Defeat 5 enemies with a single L-Ink Combo.
Untouchable	Complete a level without taking damage.
Speed Reader	Complete the game in under 5 hours.
Full Party	Play a level with a full team.
The power of Knowledge	Discover all the entries in the Codex.

5.8 Levels

As a beat 'em up, Punchline features a largely linear structure, in which players progress through a series of levels within each area, culminating in a boss fight that unlocks the next zone.

Each of the five areas consists of 7 standard levels plus 1 boss level, for a total of 40 levels with increasing difficulty. For a detailed description of each area, refer to [Section 8 The Game World](#). Boss fights are described in [Section 6.2 NPCs](#).

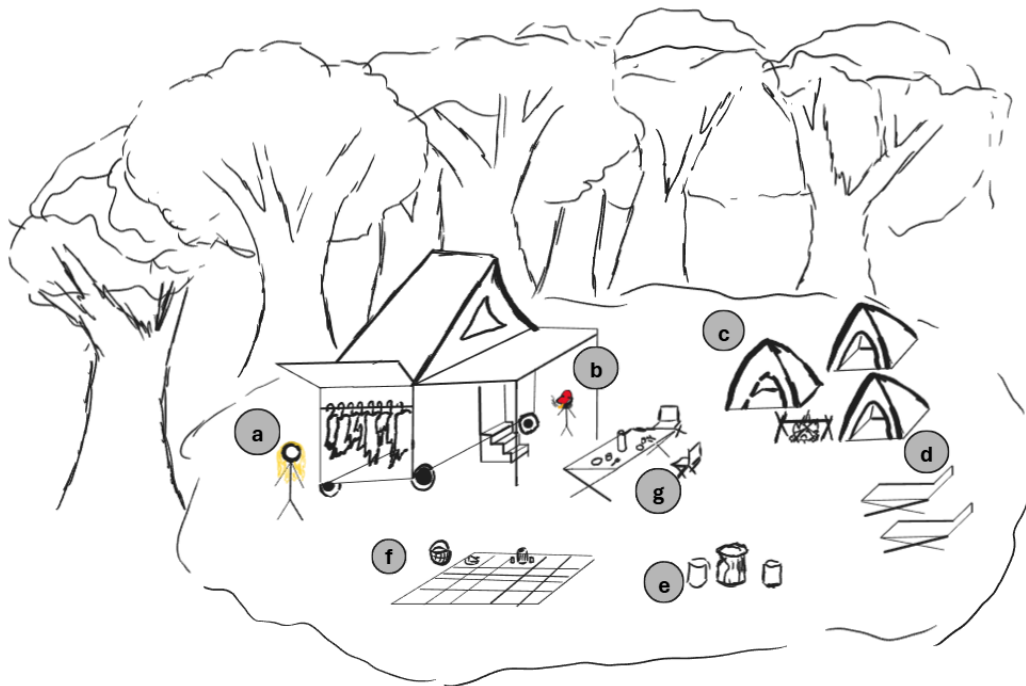


The arrows in the World Diagram indicate progression requirements: to access the next area, players must complete the previous boss fight. Similarly, boss levels are unlocked only after completing all preceding levels within that area.

The Prologue and Epilogue serve as the main cinematic sequences, while additional cutscenes are present within individual areas to introduce tutorials, narrative events, and key story developments.

5.8.1 Van

The Van serves as the main hub of the game world, where players can interact with each other, customize accessories and outfits, and access the world map. The environment surrounding the Van changes depending on the current area the players are in. This variation is purely aesthetic, while all key interactive elements remain in the same positions. For example, in the Ink Rivers the ground will appear swampy, while in Flyleaf the setting will reflect an urban environment ([see section 8 The Game World](#)).



a. Victoria

Interacting with **Victoria**, who is located near the wardrobe, allows players to access the customization menu.

b. Old Gary

Interacting with **Old Gary** allows players to access the world map, where they can select the next level.

c. Campfire

This is one of the interactive zones where players can roast marshmallows together. Interacting with the campfire starts a short timed minigame in which players must cook the marshmallow without burning it.



EXAMPLE TO MAKE THE VAN 3D MODEL



CAMPFIRE EXAMPLE

d. Deckchairs

In this area, players can lie down. Once resting, the control scheme changes, allowing players to perform specific emotes tied to this interaction, creating more relaxed and social moments.

e. Arm Wrestling Stump

Here, players can challenge each other to an arm-wrestling contest. When two players sit across from each other, a minigame begins in which they must rapidly press the attack button to overpower their opponent.

f. Picnic Area

Another social interaction space where players can sit and enjoy a picnic. Upon interacting, controls change to allow various contextual emotes, such as sitting, lying down, or dozing off.

g. Table

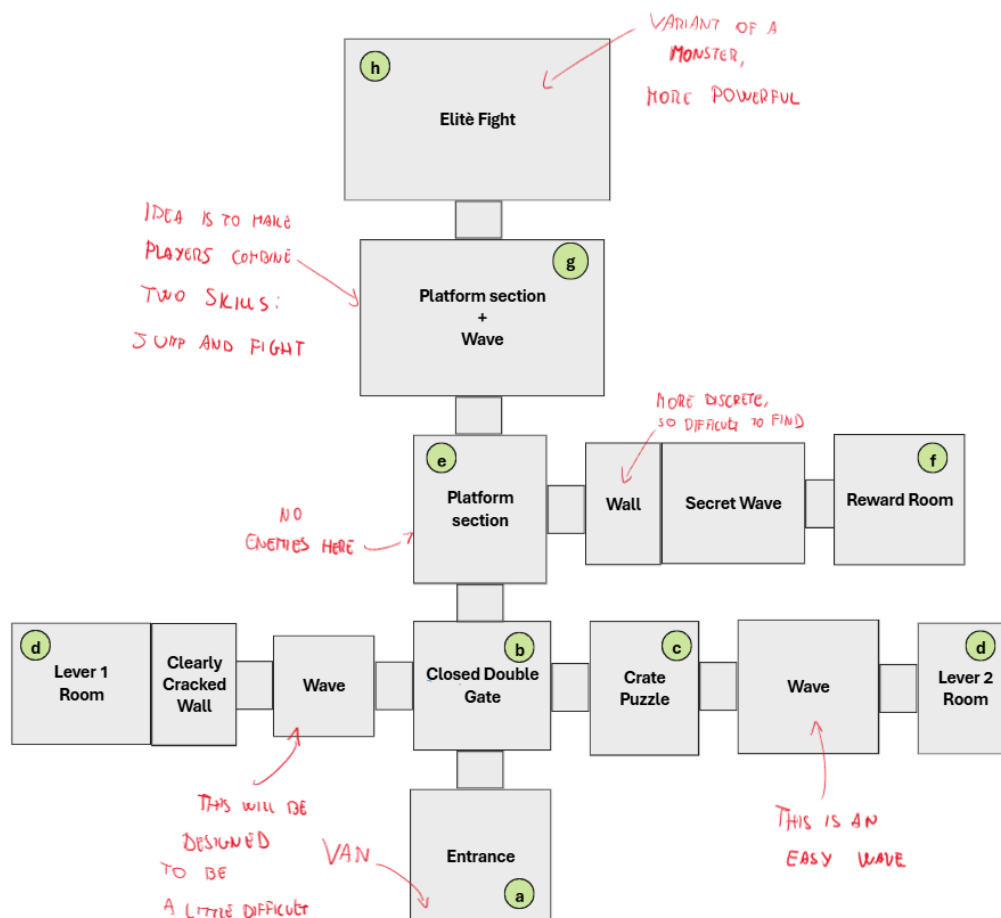
Players can sit together in this area. Once seated, they can perform a range of social emotes, such as toasting, singing, or eating.



**IDEA OF THE ARM WRESTLING
MINIGAME FROM MONSTER HUNTER**

5.8.2 Flyleaf Level

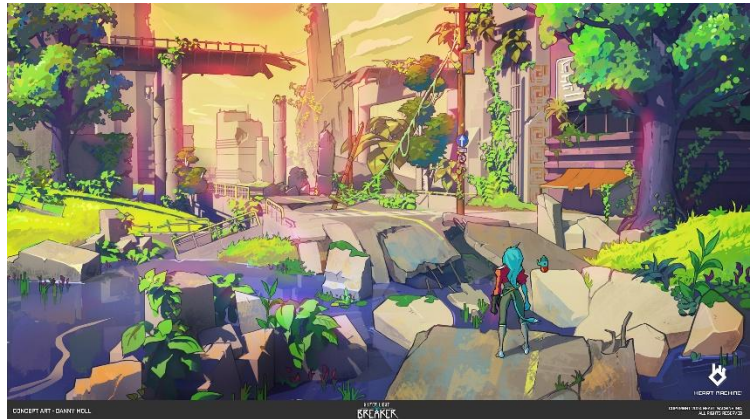
Below is the level diagram of the first Flyleaf level, provided as an example to illustrate the structure of a typical level in the game. The remaining levels will be detailed in a dedicated Level Design Document (LDD).



LEVEL DIAGRAM FOR THE FLYLEAF LEVEL

a) Entrance

As in other levels, the characters arrive by speeding in with their Van. This is the first level of Flyleaf, and its purpose is to introduce the visual identity of the area. The environment is marked by burning buildings and scattered medieval ruins that feel out of place, a direct result of Albert's distorted power reshaping reality. No enemies are present in this initial section, allowing players to take in the atmosphere.



CONCEPT ART FOR FLYLEAF (FROM HYPER LIGHT BREAKER)

Moving forward, players encounter a large double gate, recently constructed. Positioned above the gate, several **Ink Engineers** (see [section 6.2 NPCs](#)) fire on sight, forcing players to retreat into one of two side paths. The gate can be opened by activating both levers located in the level. Once one of the levers has been pulled and players return to this area, they are ambushed by the **Ink Engineers** and groups of **Page Goblins**.



STYLIZED GATE SPEEDSCULPT BY LYDIA ZANOTTI

c) Crate Puzzle

This puzzle follows the example described in [section 5.2.1 In the Levels](#). Players must move crates to create a climbable structure and progress further into the level.

d) Lever rooms

The following rooms also build upon the cooperative puzzle design described in [section 5.2.1 In the Levels](#). Players must work together to pull a lever while waves of enemies attempt to interrupt them, requiring a balance between defending teammates and completing the objective.

e) Platform section

In the next section, players encounter a large chasm. To proceed, they must jump across moving platforms, testing timing and coordination.

f) Reward room

A hidden room becomes accessible after defeating the enemies in the previous area. At the end of this secret section, players are rewarded with a cosmetic item.

g) Platform section and wave

Later, players face another platforming challenge involving moving platforms. This time, however, the camera remains fixed while waves of enemies' attack. Only after defeating all enemy waves can players safely continue.

h) Elité fight

Finally, players face an élité encounter: an enhanced and **larger Ink Engineer**. This enemy keeps players at a distance by summoning and coordinating groups of Page Goblins.

5.8.3 Albert Boss Fight

This level represents a boss area, specifically the final encounter against Albert. His attacks are described in detail in [section 6.2 NPCs](#). This section focuses instead on the arena and additional elements that go beyond the boss's behavior.

The top of the Infinite Library is a large, enclosed arena surrounded by towering bookshelves filled with tomes, manuscripts, and ancient volumes. Positioned on opposite sides of the arena, just out of the players' reach, are two large magical crystals.

After a cinematic in which Albert makes one final attempt to convince the players to join him, the battle begins.

First Phase

As described in [section 6.2 NPCs](#), when Albert's health reaches 0%, he rises into the air and begins channeling energy from the crystals, restoring himself while remaining out of the players' reach. The first time this occurs, a short dialogue is triggered with Aria, who believes she can help the protagonists.

From the second occurrence onward, Aria uses her magic to create temporary platforms leading up to the crystals. At this point, players can reach and destroy the crystals, preventing Albert from healing.

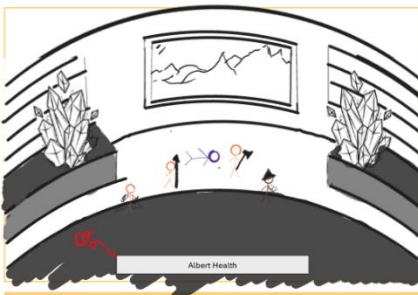
Albert First Phase: Destroying Crystals

This storyboard explains how things go when Albert reaches 0% health in the first phase.

CONTEXT

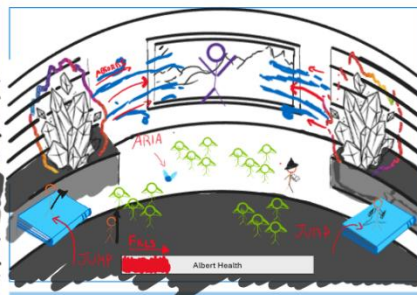
The players just fight Albert, and took it to 0% health.

Albert at 0% Health



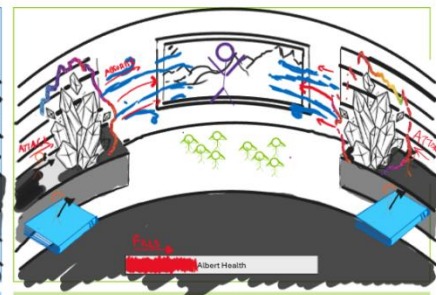
Here, the players just took Albert at 0% health.

Albert starts healing



But Albert begins channeling energy from the crystals, healing himself! So Aria creates floating platforms to reach the crystals and players start jumping on the platforms to reach them, while making their way between monsters.

Players start destroying crystals



Players reached the crystals and start hitting them.

Second Phase

At the start of the second phase, a cinematic sequence shows the arena lifting into the sky, breaking through the ceiling of the structure. From this moment on, players can fall off the arena if they are not careful.

One of Albert's attacks in this phase, **Ink Mastery**, affects the entire arena. The only way to survive the attack is to take cover behind magical barriers created by Aria, which appear randomly across the arena in sufficient number for all players. Simply positioning behind these barriers is enough to avoid the damage.

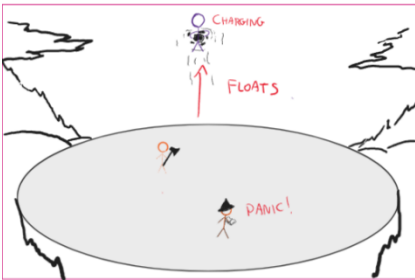
Once the fight concludes, the final cinematic is triggered, bringing the game to its conclusion.

Evading Ink Mastery attack in Albert's Second Phase

This storyboard explains the flow of the Ink Mastery attack, and how the players are supposed to evade it.

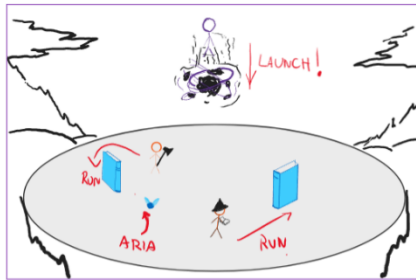
In the second phase of the Albert Boss Fight, he has just reached one of the health threshold that triggers the attack, and is beginning to launch it!

Albert begins to charge the attack



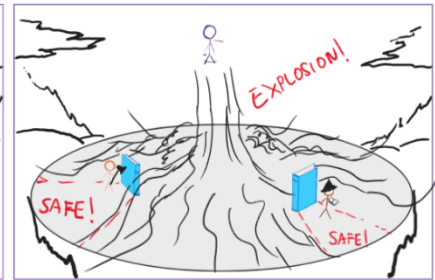
Albert arrived at one of the health thresholds, so the attack Ink Mastery triggers. Albert floats and starts to charge the attack.

Aria creates the barriers



While Albert charges, Aria makes barriers emerge from the ground, so that players can hide behind them.

Players take cover



The players successfully hide behind barriers, taking no damage.

6. Game Characters

6.1 Playable Characters

In this section, the playable characters will be introduced, outlining their backstory, their role within the main narrative, and their physical appearance. Additionally, a selection of example abilities will be presented.

These examples are neither exhaustive nor final, as each character's move set will be further developed in collaboration with the artist responsible for creating the required animations ([see section 9 Media List](#)). As such, the abilities described here should be considered as a general indication of the intended playstyle for each character in the final product.

6.1.1 James Miller

Before the adventure, **James Miller** was a university rugby instructor, a very sturdy and disciplined man with a stern appearance, recognizable by his shaved head, the scar over his left eye, and his college rugby coat.

Once the journey begins, his physical strength and protective nature evolve into the role of a true frontliner, making him the teammate who withstands pressure and leads the group through the most dangerous encounters.

His weapon is a heavy axe inspired by his favorite book, **Crime and Punishment**, and it represents brute force, impact, and determination, with slow but devastating strikes that are ideal for breaking enemy lines and protecting allies.



JAMES' AXE CONCEPT ART BY LEANDRO JOLLDASHI



**JAMES MILLER CONCEPT ART BY
LEANDRO JOLLDASHI**

Stats Examples

James has **100 HP**, below a list of attacks examples:

Button sequence	Name	Description	Damage
A->B (Hold for another effect)	Groundbreaker	James slams his axe forcefully into the ground, dealing damage in a small area around the impact. While the button is held, James maintains the stance, creating a shield in front of him. If this shield is broken by an attack, James suffers substantial damage. This shield regenerates over time.	7->19
A->A->B	Vortex	James uses the centrifugal force and weight of his weapon to spin rapidly toward nearby enemies, striking them multiple times.	7->11->23
A->A->A->B	Axe Throw	After a series of slashes, James throws his axe, hitting enemies at medium range. The axe then returns to him, dealing additional damage on its way back.	7->11->13->29
A->A->A->A->B (Hold to charge)	Punishment	After the slashes, James charges forward in a powerful plunge attack. The longer the B button is held, the greater the distance covered and the impact of the attack.	7->11->13->17->31

6.1.2 Anastasia Mary

Before her transformation, Anastasia Mary was an elegant television host of art documentaries, tall, refined, and gifted with an almost model-like presence, always carrying herself with confidence and sophistication.

When the adventure begins, her cultural sensitivity and emotional strength turn into support-oriented powers, allowing her to become a figure who helps the group through protection, healing, and magical assistance.

Her weapon is a magical book inspired by her favorite book, *Pride and Prejudice*, from which she draws the power to cast offensive spells, defend her companions, and heal them through magic shaped by emotional intelligence, affection, and resolve.



**ANASTASIA MARY CONCEPT ART BY
LEANDRO JOLLDASHI**

Stats Examples

Anastasia has **70 HP**, below a list of attacks examples:

Button sequence	Name	Description	Damage
A->B (Hold to charge)	Healing Fireball	Anastasia charges a small fireball. The longer the attack is charged, the larger its impact radius becomes. If it hits an ally, it restores a small amount of health.	3->13
A->A->B	Light Column	Anastasia summons a column of light in front of her coming from above, slamming enemies into the ground.	3->5->17
A->A->A->B	Healing Sigil	Anastasia places a sigil on the ground. Allies standing within its area gradually restore a small amount of health over time.	3->5->7-> (standing in the sigil heals 1 point every second for 10 sec.)
A->A->A->A->B	Pride	Anastasia dashes forward, enveloped in flames. This attack covers a long distance and is effective for repositioning.	3->5->7->11->23



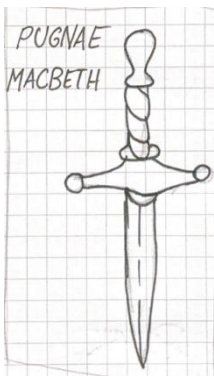
ANASTASIA'S BOOK CONCEPT ART BY LEANDRO JOLLDASHI

6.1.3 Jill Sellen

Before the adventure, Jill Sellen was a talented writer, reflective and elegant, with shoulder-length hair, glasses, and an appearance that conveyed intelligence, sensitivity, and inner calm.

After the journey begins, her observant nature and quick mind are transformed into a fast and precise fighting style, making her the most agile member of the group.

She fights with a pair of daggers inspired by her favorite book, Macbeth, designed for chaining rapid attacks, striking vulnerable targets, and allowing her to constantly reposition herself on the battlefield.



JILL'S DAGGER CONCEPT ART BY LEANDRO JOLLDASHI



JILL SELLEN CONCEPT ART BY LEANDRO JOLLDASHI

Stats Examples

Jill has **60 HP**, below a list of attacks examples:

Button sequence	Name	Description	Damage
A->B	Assassinate	Jill teleports a short distance and strikes the target from behind. If the attack hits an enemy from the back, it deals double damage.	2->11
A->A->B	Slide	Jill performs a quick slide, knocking down enemies hit along her path.	2->3->13
A->A->A->B	Flurry of Knives	Jill continuously throws daggers forward, covering a short distance. Holding the button allows her to keep throwing knives in rapid succession.	2->3->5->17
A->A->A->A->B	Walking Shadow	Jill dives into the shadows and re-emerges in a column of darkness, damaging enemies in a small area and launching them into the air.	2->3->5->7->19

6.1.4 Leon Castellanos

Before his transformation, Leon Castellanos was a charming stage actor passionate about Greek drama, charismatic, cultured, and naturally inclined to command attention.

Once the adventure begins, his theatrical charm turns into courage and heroic presence, making him the most balanced member of the team, capable of adapting both to direct combat and to controlling space in battle.

His weapon is a lance inspired by his favorite book, Don Quixote, symbolizing momentum, courage, and the will to face any obstacle, while giving him both effective reach and solid versatility in combat.



**LEON'S LANCE CONCEPT ART BY
LEANDRO JOLLDASHI**



**LEON CASTELLANOS CONCEPT ART BY
LEANDRO JOLLDASHI**

Stats Examples

Leon has **80 HP**, below a list of attacks examples:

Button sequence	Name	Description	Damage
A->B (Hold to charge)	Javelin	Leon throws his lance like a javelin. Charging the attack alters the trajectory and increases its range and impact.	3->13
A->A->B (Hold to continue attacking)	Continuous impale	Leon repeatedly thrusts his lance forward, striking enemies in front of him. Holding the button allows him to continue the attack.	3->5->17
A->A->A->B	Incitation	Leon slams his lance into the ground while chanting, damaging nearby enemies and granting a temporary attack speed bonus to allies in the area.	3->5->7->19
A->A->A->A->B	Charge	Leon rushes forward with his lance, impaling enemies and pushing them along his path. This attack is effective for repositioning enemies and setting them up for teammates' attacks.	3->5->7->11->23

6.1.5 L-Ink Combo Examples

Combination	Name	Cost (Inspiration bar notches)	L-Ink Combo effect	Damage
Vortex (James) + Healing Fireball (Anastasia)	Fire Tornado	2	The fireball is caught in James's vortex, splitting into multiple smaller fireballs that spin around him and hit nearby enemies.	33
Light Column (Anastasia) + Walking Shadow (Jill)	Antimatter Explosion	3	Light and darkness collide, creating a large explosion that deals heavy damage to enemies in a wide area.	29
Incitation (Leon) + Healing Sigil (Anastasia)	Healing Explosion	3	Leon's chanting overloads the sigil, causing it to burst into healing particles that restore health to allies in a larger area.	Heals 20 points to allies in the area.
Javelin (Leon) + Punishment (James)	Double Trouble	1	James grabs Leon's lance mid-charge, using it as a pivot to launch a second charge in the opposite direction, hitting enemies twice.	35

6.2 NPCs

All NPCs basic info will be available in game in the Codex section of the pause menu ([see section 5.4.2 Codex](#)).

Aria

Story

Aria is the Fairy of Books and will accompany the protagonists throughout their journey, offering helpful advice and allowing them to enhance their abilities, growing more in tune with the Heroes they embody.

Hundreds of years ago, when magic still flowed through the world, she sealed herself inside a book to escape from humans who, frightened by her power, had tried to destroy her. Since then, the book has remained hidden within the library of Silent Whispers waiting for someone with a boundless love for stories.

Once freed by Albert Redfield, Aria granted him the power to summon ink-born creatures from the pages of books, unaware of the consequences such a gift would bring.

Personality

Aria is deeply innocent and naive. She always tries to see the good in everyone, even in those who commit evil acts, and struggles to understand cruelty. At the same time, she is extremely curious. The modern world, so different from the one she remembers, fascinates and confuses her, often leading to humorous situations and small misunderstandings.

Appearance

She has an ethereal and luminous appearance, with long, light blue hair that seems to move as if carried by an invisible breeze. Her large, bright eyes recall the tones of the sky, while her body emits a soft glow. Every movement is light and harmonious, and when she uses her powers, thin luminous trails resembling floating musical notes seem to follow her.

While not in her human form, Aria becomes a little azure energy ball, following the characters through the levels.



NAVI (FROM THE LEGEND OF ZELDA) COSPLAY BY JINA D, AN IDEA FOR ARIA APPEARANCE

Albert Redfield

Story

Albert is the founder of the Four Wheels Book Club. A lifelong lover of literature, he devoted his life to the study of mythology and folklore. He has always been fascinated by the fact that, across vastly different cultures, fantastical creatures often share striking similarities and common traits.

Over the years, this led him to believe that the beings described in myths and legends must have truly existed at some point, and that they mysteriously vanished.

He founded the Four Wheels Book Club both to share his passion with as many people as possible and, secretly, to search for evidence to support his theory. Over time, however, as he witnessed bookstores disappearing and society gradually forgetting the importance of culture and books, his once pure ideals began to decay. He became convinced that not everyone deserves access to knowledge, and that the world needs someone capable of deciding what should be preserved and what should be forgotten.

The discovery of the book containing Aria marked a turning point. At last, he saw a way to bring his vision to life: a world where all culture is gathered under his control. Using the power granted to him by the Fairy of Books after freeing her, Albert plans to build the **Infinite Library**, an immense archive where all stories, ideas, and history are reduced to a single unified narrative under his direct authority, accessible only to a chosen few.

Appearance

Albert is a man in his thirties, with a strong and well-built physique. He has long, dark hair tied back in a low ponytail.

When the protagonists encounter him again at the top of the Infinite Library, his appearance has changed significantly. He wears a long, flowing purple robe, richly embroidered with golden patterns and tied at the waist with a black rope belt.

His face is gaunt, as though worn down by obsession and sleepless nights. His eyes are slightly reddened, surrounded by deep, pronounced dark circles that mark the toll his relentless pursuit of control has taken on him.

Fight

The final encounter takes place at the top of the Infinite Library, where Albert has fully mastered his powers and learned to draw upon the abilities of his own commanders. As a result, several of his attacks in the second phase are enhanced or reimagined versions of abilities previously used by bosses encountered throughout the game.

As the final boss fight, the encounter with Albert is designed to be the most challenging in the entire game, testing both individual skill and team coordination.



**ALBERT REDFIELD CONCEPT ART BY
LEANDRO JOLLDASHI**



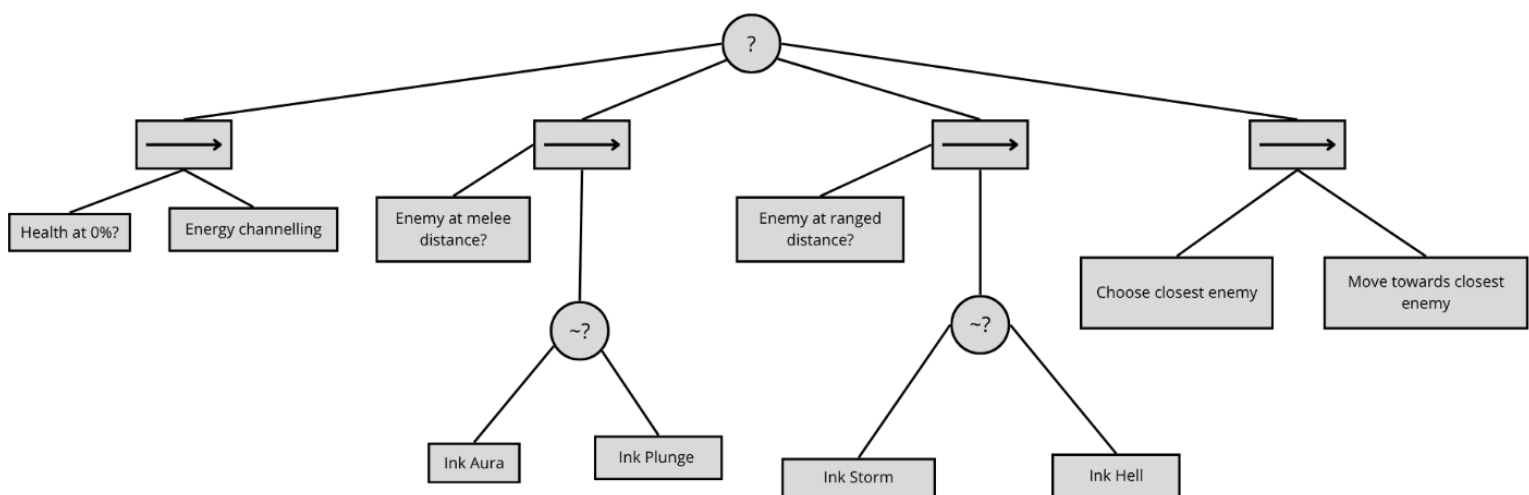
CONCEPT FOR ALBERT'S HFSM

First Phase

During the first phase, Albert primarily relies on large area-of-effect attacks, controlling the battlefield and forcing players to constantly reposition (see table below for a list of the attacks). In this phase, he is effectively invulnerable. When his health reaches 0%, instead of being defeated, he rises into the air, out of the players' reach, and begins channeling energy from two large green magical crystals to fully restore his health. While doing so, he continuously summons waves of minor enemies to pressure the players and prevent them from focusing solely on the true objective of this phase.

The players' goal in this phase is in fact not to defeat Albert directly, but to destroy the crystals and prevent him from regenerating ([see section 5.5.3 Albert Boss Fight](#)). The crystals are reachable only when Albert is healing himself.

Once all the crystals have been destroyed and Albert's health is brought to zero again, the first phase comes to an end.



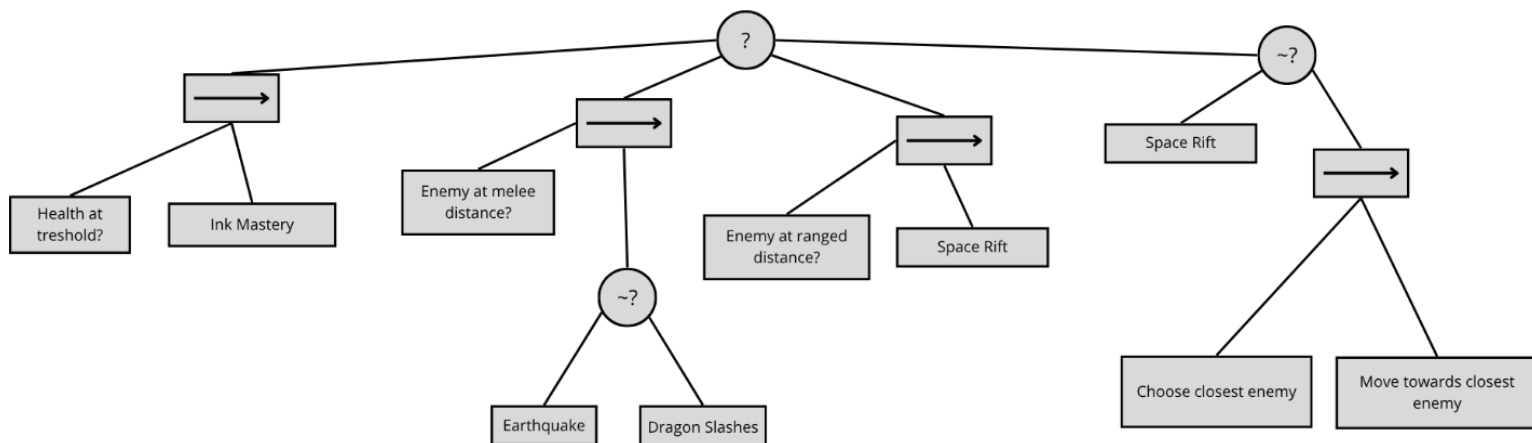
CONCEPT FOR ALBERT'S FIRST PHASE BT

Attack name	Description
Ink Storm	Albert summons multiple Page Goblins around him, which fire darts upward in arcing trajectories, creating a chaotic rain of projectiles that fall back toward the players.
Ink Aura	A close-range defensive attack that triggers a large explosion around Albert. The blast deals low damage but heavily knocks back nearby players. Visually, the attack is represented by multiple Ink Crawlers erupting simultaneously around him.
Ink Hell	Albert summons several Ink Engineers , which immediately deploy turrets unleashing a barrage of projectiles in all directions.
Ink Plunge	Albert summons a formation of ink-constructed Page Knights that charge forward in a coordinated assault. These units move in a straight line.
Energy channeling	Used only when his health reaches 0%, he rises into the air, out of the players' reach, and begins channeling energy from two large magical crystals to fully restore his health.

Second phase

In the second phase, Albert loses control completely. His fighting style becomes more aggressive and unpredictable, and he begins to unleash attacks inspired by the various bosses previously encountered (see table below for a list of the attacks).

Once defeated, a final cutscene is triggered, bringing the story to its conclusion.



CONCEPT FOR ALBERT'S SECOND PHASE BT

Attack name	Description
Dragon slashes	A furious melee combo inspired by the Bibliodragon, consisting of multiple rapid strikes. At the end of the sequence, Albert briefly pauses, leaving a short window for players to counterattack.
Earthquake	Albert conjures a massive club like Ragh's weapon and slams it repeatedly into the ground, generating shockwaves that deal heavy area damage and pushes players away.
Space Rift	Albert teleports instantly near a targeted player, tearing through space itself, and unleashes a powerful area-of-effect explosion upon arrival quickly.
Ink Mastery	Albert lifts himself and absorbs the ink from the surrounding books, unleashing a powerful bomb in the center of the stage. The bomb does massive damage and covers all the arena. This attack is unleashed at 75%, 50% and 25% health

Ink-Monsters

Ink Monsters are the primary enemies of the game, encompassing a wide variety of enemy types. All of them are creations of Albert, and as the game progresses, they become increasingly dangerous, coordinated, and specialized. The description of the **Ink-Monsters** and their attacks will be reported in the **Codex** section of the **Pause Menu** ([see section 5.4.2 Codex](#)). Below are some examples:

Ink Crawler

A deformed humanoid creature made of dense, shifting ink. Its body is fluid and unstable, with elongated or disproportionate limbs that constantly stretch and recoil. It attacks using its own mass, throwing itself at enemies in crude but effective ways.

Attack name	Description
Ink Splash	Upon death, the creature bursts into a pool of ink that lingers on the ground, slowing any player who steps into it, fading away after a bit of time.
Ink Swipe	A slow melee attack in which the Ink Crawler lunges forward with its full body weight, dealing moderate damage but covering a short area in front of it



INK CRAWLER (SLOBBER FROM DISNEY EPIC MICKEY) MOLDED (RESIDENT EVIL7)

Page Goblin

A small creature resembling a goblin, with a body made of folded and crumpled pages. It has thin, twitchy fingers and eyes that look like shifting ink blots. Its movements are quick and erratic.

Attack name	Description
Tar Trap	Places sticky tar-like traps on the ground that detonate upon contact, dealing damage and briefly immobilizing players caught in the blast.
Blowpipe	Fires small darts from a distance. Individually weak, but dangerous when used in rapid succession.



ASSASSIN GOBLIN CONCEPT ART
(RADIANCE)

Ink Stalker

A slender, elongated creature with a serpentine form, made of liquid ink. It prefers to remain hidden beneath the surface of dark waters, waiting patiently for the right moment to strike. Only its glowing, elongated eyes are clearly visible above the surface.

Attack name	Description
Ambush	A sudden, high-damage strike launched from below, catching players off guard if they are not paying attention to the water's surface.
Drag Down	After a successful Ambush , the Ink Stalker attempts to pull the target underwater. Players can break free through rapid movement or by having another teammate hit the monster hard enough, temporarily exposing the creature to attacks.



AZHDAHA CONCEPT ART
(PRINCE OF PERSIA)

Bog Witch

A twisted witch with long, flowing hair made of dripping ink, which forms pools beneath her feet. She wears garments made of layered parchment, and her fingers are sharp like razors. She uses the ink around her to move unpredictably across the battlefield.

Attack name	Description
Bl-Ink Warp	Instantly teleports between pools of ink scattered across the arena.
Ink Hex	Summons a glowing sigil on the ground that detonates after a short delay, dealing area damage.



CARMINA MORA
(DEAD BY DAYLIGHT)

Paper Knight

A humanoid knight composed of hardened, layered paper, shaped into elegant but unnatural armor. It wields a weapon resembling a giant fountain pen used as a lance, and carries a shield made of hardened sealing wax.

Attack name	Description
Guard Stance	The Paper Knight raises its shield and begins to glow, entering a defensive stance. If struck from the front, it performs a powerful counterattack. Attacking it from behind or with a sufficiently strong attack can break its guard.
Lunge Strike	A fast, long-distance thrust that allows the knight to quickly close the gap and deals high single-target damage.



THE KNIGHT OF AVON (MOBINOGI)

FOUNTAIN PEN LANCE (MOBINOGI)

Ashen Reader

A humanoid figure composed of charred and smoldering pages. Its body burns constantly without ever being consumed. It manipulates fire-infused paper both at range and in close combat.

Attack name	Description
Burning Pages	Launches fast-moving projectiles made of flaming paper in a straight line. On impact, they leave behind burning zones that deal damage over time.
Flame Strike	A close-range attack that triggers a small explosion of fire around the target.



PHILIP THE CRYING CHILDREN
(LIBRARY OF RUINA)

Ink Engineer

A more advanced ink creature, partially structured with crude mechanical elements. Gears and components emerge from its body, which it uses to construct simple machines. It tends to avoid direct confrontation, constantly repositioning.

Attack name	Description
Ink-fire Bombs	Throws arcing projectiles that explode on impact, creating zones of burning ink that both damage and slow players.
Ink Turret	Deploys a destructible turret that fires dense blobs of ink at players.



THE KEEPERS
(BENDY AND THE DARK REVIVAL)

Word Phantom

A floating entity made of overlapping, shifting words and fragments of sentences. Its form is unstable, constantly rearranging itself as if rewritten in real time. It moves gracefully, almost like a dancer suspended in the air.

Attack name	Description
Phrase Shout	Emits loud, distorted vocalizations that materialize into onomatopoeic words, which then shoot forward as projectiles, damaging anyone in their path.



FEAR
(TYPOMAN)

Ragh the Orc

Description

Ragh is a massive orc with exaggerated musculature, its body constantly dripping with ink. It wields a crude, oversized club made from debris and tightly bound pages, fused together through magic.

Ragh is the boss of the [Cover Hills](#) and is supported by a group of Page Goblins that follow his command, albeit in a chaotic and disorganized manner. As the first of Albert's summoned commanders, he is also the least powerful and least intelligent among them. However, what he lacks in strategy, he makes up for in brute strength and relentless aggression.

Driven by a simple desire to prove himself, Ragh seeks to climb Albert's hierarchy through sheer force. He does not fully understand Albert's goal, nor would he likely be able to grasp it even if explained. Nevertheless, he feels a deep sense of gratitude toward his creator for bringing him into existence and holds a profound respect for Albert's power.

Fight

In battle, Ragh relies on physical attacks, wide swings, and ground-shaking blows, often calling upon Page Goblins to assist him.

Attack name	Description
Ground Slam	Ragh lifts his massive weapon high above his head before slamming it violently into the ground, dealing heavy damage in a wide area around the impact point. The force of the blow causes his crude club to partially shatter, leaving fragments scattered across the battlefield. During this moment, Ragh is briefly vulnerable as he focuses on magically reassembling his weapon, creating an opening for players to attack.
Rallying	Ragh calls for reinforcement, summoning a group of Page Goblins to fight alongside him
Charge	Ragh lowers his stance and rushes forward in a straight line, trampling anything in his path. Players hit by the charge are knocked back and briefly stunned.
Uplifting Roar	Ragh lets out a thunderous roar, issuing crude commands to the nearby Page Goblins. All allied goblins within range gain a boost to movement speed and attack speed for a short duration.
Club Strike	Ragh uses its club to hit a wide area in front of it.



THE BEAST (BENDY AND THE INK MACHINE)



OLOG-HAI (LORD OF THE RINGS)

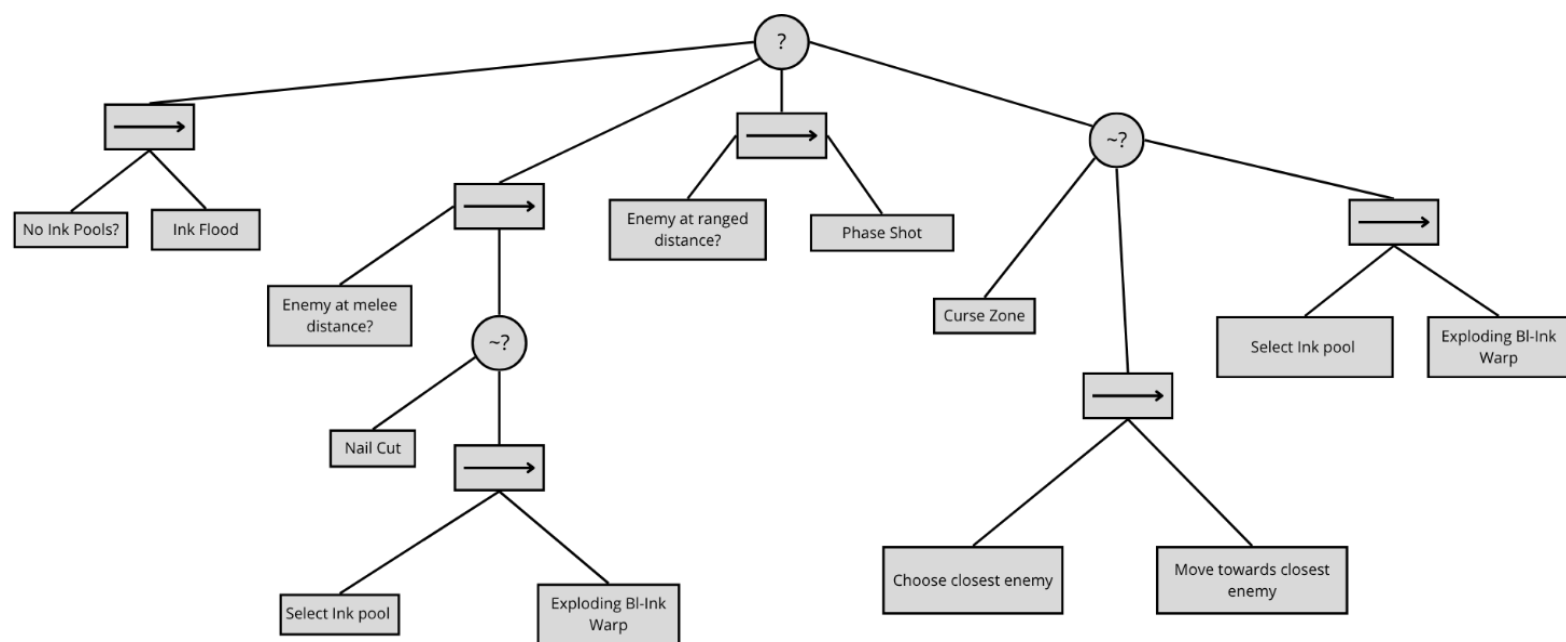
Lady Millicent

Description

Lady Millicent is an ancient witch who has, over the centuries, mastered the art of spatial magic, developing powerful techniques of movement and teleportation that she once taught to the sisters of her coven. She is the very same witch of local legend tied to the region now known as the [Ink Rivers](#), a figure spoken of in whispers long before Albert's arrival. Rather than being subdued by Albert, Millicent has entered into an agreement with him, seeing in his power an opportunity to further expand her own influence. Tasked with halting the protagonists, she now acts as the guardian of the region, bending both space and the corrupted environment to her will.

Despite her immense age, Millicent retains the appearance of a strikingly beautiful young woman, a trait she takes great pride in. She has long, raven-black hair and wears a distinctive pointed hat, paired with elegant garments that seem to be woven from shadows. Her movements are graceful, almost theatrical, masking the deadly precision of her magic.

Fight



CONCEPT FOR LADY MILLICENT'S BT

Attack name	Description
Ink Flood	Millicent floods the arena with corrosive ink, dealing continuous damage to any player caught within it. Shortly before the attack, elevated platforms rise from the terrain, offering safe zones. Once the ink recedes, it leaves behind multiple pools that remain active.
Curse Zone	Millicent conjures glowing sigils on the ground that remain dormant until triggered. These sigils detonate when touched by a player or ink, dealing significant area damage.
Exploding Bl- Ink Warp	Millicent teleports between pools of ink scattered across the battlefield. Upon reappearing, she triggers a localized explosion, and the used pool fades.
Phase Shot	Millicent fires a projectile that tears through space itself. Players struck by it take damage and are instantly teleported to a random location within the arena. The attack is telegraphed by a visible targeting reticule, giving attentive players a chance to evade it.
Nail Cut	When players get too close, Millicent extends her nails to unnatural lengths and slashes in a wide arc in front of her. This attack deals damage and pushes targets away.



BAYONETTA
(FROM BAYONETTA)

Bibliodragon

Description

The **Bibliodragon** is a towering and formidable entity, one of Albert's most refined creations, born from his growing mastery over magic. It is an automaton-like being, as if assembled from the remnants of an entire library: ink, sealing wax, books, and broken shelves fused together into a colossal draconic form. Within this constructed body resides the essence of a legendary dragon drawn from fairy tales.

Under Albert's command, the Bibliodragon has laid waste to the city now known as [Flyleaf](#), reducing entire districts to ruins. Even now, it patrols the skies above the area, ready to intercept anyone who dares to approach. The encounter takes place atop the tallest buildings of Flyleaf, where players must face it in a precarious, elevated battlefield.

Attack name	Description
Fire Breath	The Bibliodragon unleashes a powerful stream of fire from its jaws, sweeping across a large area. Before executing the attack, it charges for a noticeable duration and holds its head still, clearly telegraphing the direction of the incoming breath and giving players time to react.
Foot Stomp	The Bibliodragon slams one of its massive limbs onto the ground, dealing heavy damage in the surrounding area.
Wing Beat	With a forceful flap of its wings, the Bibliodragon generates shockwaves that push players away, potentially knocking over the edges of platforms.
Ink Blast	The Bibliodragon raises its wings and releases volleys of dense ink projectiles from them, aimed at more targets.
Bite	The Bibliodragon lunges forward to bite a target. This attack has a wide hitbox and can damage multiple players standing close together.



DRAGON
(FINAL FANTASY XVI)

Kromar the Titan

Description

Kromar is the last giant of the mountains, the sole surviving member of an ancient and nearly forgotten race. He has allied himself with Albert, persuaded by the promise that, once his grand plan is complete, magic will be used to restore his people and bring his race back from extinction.

Kromar is an imposing figure even among giants. He has vivid red hair, shaved at the sides and tied into a short ponytail, and a long, thick red beard braided with silver rings. He wears a worn brown tunic, weathered by time and harsh mountain conditions. His body is marked by striking blue tattoos, formed by patterns of broken concentric circles that seem to faintly glow.

Despite his intimidating presence, there is a sense of solemnity to him. Kromar is not driven by cruelty, but by loss and hope, clinging to Albert's promise as his last chance to restore what has been taken from him.

Fight

The fight against Kromar is highly unique and differs significantly from traditional boss encounters. Rather than facing him directly from the start, players must ascend to his head by climbing an enormous beanstalk that stretches up along the mountainside.

As they climb, players will encounter waves of enemies and platforming challenges, requiring coordination, timing, and spatial awareness. The ascent itself becomes part of the battle, as Kromar actively interferes, attempting to stop the players before they can reach him.

Old Gary

Story

Old Gary is the oldest member of the Four Wheels Book Club, as well as one of its original founders. Before retiring, he worked as a mechanic for his entire life. He is now responsible for driving and maintaining the Van, the symbolic heart of the club.

Thanks to Gary, the Van is far more than just a vehicle. He personally designed and installed many of its upgrades and comforts, including features such as a small picnic area and a compact wardrobe space for the team. His craftsmanship has turned the Van into a place where the group can rest, regroup, and prepare for their next journey.

Unlike the other members, Gary was not granted the ability to channel the power of a literary hero by Aria. According to him, he is perfectly fine with that: *"I'll leave the fun to the youngsters, I'll just drive them around."* Gary is a caring and dependable figure, often acting like a grandfather to the rest of the team, offering advice and support.

Description

Old Gary is a man in his sixties, with a short and stocky build. He is slightly hunched, both due to his age and the many years spent bent over engines and machinery.

He always wears a worn cap and a pair of dark sunglasses. His hair and beard are thick and white, often unkempt, with occasional traces of engine oil.



CONCEPT ART FOR OLD GARY

**(SKIPPY ROERICH FROM
FALLOUT 76, BY STEVAN
LONCAREVIC)**

A well-used pipe is almost always resting between his lips, rarely lit but constantly present. His clothes are practical and durable, consisting of a mechanic's jacket, sturdy trousers, and heavy boots, all marked by years of use and dotted with grease stains.

During the game

In gameplay terms, Gary serves as the link between the Van hub area and the World map. The Van acts as a safe space where players can relax, interact with NPCs, customize their appearance, and switch characters. By interacting with Gary, a dialogue prompt will appear asking the player if they are ready to depart. Upon confirmation, the game transitions to the world map, where the next level can be selected.

Gary is present from the very beginning of the game within the Van area ([see section 5.5.1 Van](#)).

Victoria

Story

Victoria is the youngest member of the Four Wheels Book Club. At first glance, she may come across as snobbish and superficial, but beneath that exterior she is kind, sensitive, and unapologetically eccentric.

She has been an avid reader since childhood, and her passion for literature has always grown alongside her love for fashion. Before the events of the game, she was studying to become a fashion designer. Her dream is to see her creations, inspired by fairy tales and classic stories, showcased on the most prestigious runways in the world.

Victoria has been granted the ability to channel the power of a literary figure, although not one suited for direct combat. The hero she resonates with most is the Fairy Godmother. Through this connection, she gains the ability to conjure clothing and accessories.

Description

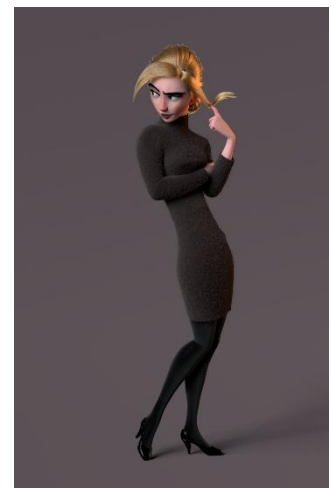
Victoria is a young woman in her early twenties, with a slender and elegant figure. She carries herself with confidence, often standing with a theatrical posture. She has long, carefully styled blonde hair and deep blue eyes.

Victoria constantly wears outfits of her own design, blending modern fashion with elements inspired by fairy tales and classic literature. Flowing fabrics, layered textures, and intricate details give her a look that feels both contemporary and fantastic.

During the game

In gameplay terms, Victoria serves as the main hub for character customization. By bringing her items found throughout the levels, players can unlock new outfits and cosmetic options. These designs often reflect different literary inspirations.

Victoria is present from the very beginning of the game within the Van area ([see section 5.5.1 Van](#)).



**VICTORIA CONCEPT ART
(BLONDE GIRL BY BRITTANY
MYERS, CHARLES ELLISON)**

6.3 Enemy Chart

Monster\Area	Cover Hills	Ink Rivers	Flyleaf	Page Valley	Spine Mountain
Ink Crawler	X	X			X
Page Goblin	X	X	X		
Ink Stalker		X			X
Bog Witch		X		X	
Paper Knight			X	X	X
Ashen Reader			X	X	
Ink Engineer			X		X
Word Phantom				X	X
Ragh The Orc	X				
Lady Millicent		X			
Bibliodragon			X		
Kromar				X	
Albert					X

7. Story

7.1 Synopsis

A cursed book, one that should never have been opened, ends up in the hands of the members of the Four Wheels Book Club. Though the book is sealed with an archaic sigil and everyone agrees it should remain closed, the club leader, Albert Redfield, cannot resist his curiosity. Breaking the seal, he releases Aria, a kind yet naïve fairy gifted with the power to grant magical abilities.

In gratitude for her freedom, Aria grants Albert the power to summon Ink-born creatures from the pages of books. But the gift quickly corrupts him. Drunk on his newfound strength, he fills the library with twisted incarnations of classic literary villains, casts Aria aside, and sets his sights on conquering the world.

Determined to stop him, Aria turns to the other members of the Book Club, granting them the ability to channel the powers of literature's greatest heroes. Through collaboration, strategy, and a touch of luck, they must track Albert the Sorcerer, defeat him, and, if possible, bring him back to his senses.

And so, begins their journey, fueled by flying fists and the roaring engine of their Van, along treacherous roads and against formidable foes, as they fight to defeat the Ink monsters unleashed by Albert.

7.2 Complete story

Since the game is primarily aimed at Socializers and Casual Gamers, the story will not be a dominant component of the full experience, but rather a narrative thread that supports the gameplay. The first level, in addition to serving as a tutorial, will allow players to understand the game world and provide the main objectives.

7.2.1 Introduction

The members of the “Four Wheels Book Club” gather for one of their Book Trips, small excursions dedicated to discovering new stories and sharing their love for books. Traveling in their trusted van, they arrive at a small, isolated library, tucked away from the noise of the modern world. There, they uncover a hidden chamber buried beneath the building. At its center rests an ancient manuscript, bound in worn leather and sealed with an archaic sigil that pulses faintly. The title reads: “*Sealed Legends.*”

A sense of unease spreads among the group. Even the most curious members hesitate, but everyone agrees that the book should remain untouched. Everyone, however, except Albert Redfield, the charismatic club leader. Known for his relentless hunger for knowledge, Albert dismisses their concerns. Convinced that no story should remain unread, he breaks the seal.

As the sigil shatters, a surge of luminous energy fills the room. From the pages emerges Aria, a gentle and radiant fairy who speaks with innocence untouched by the passage of time. She reveals that she sealed herself within the book centuries ago to escape humans who feared her power.

Grateful for her freedom, Aria grants Albert a blessing: the power to summon ink-born creatures from the pages of books.

But the gift quickly corrupts him. Drunk on his newfound strength, Albert begins to twist the stories, summoning not heroes but villains, warped and monstrous versions of literary antagonists reshaped by his will. He starts to fill the library with ink creatures, realizing that he finally can achieve his dream.

Aria and the other members of the club, horrified by what the gift has become, try to intervene. But Albert, now consumed by his vision, casts her aside, dismissing her as nothing more than a tool, and causes the other club members to lose consciousness.

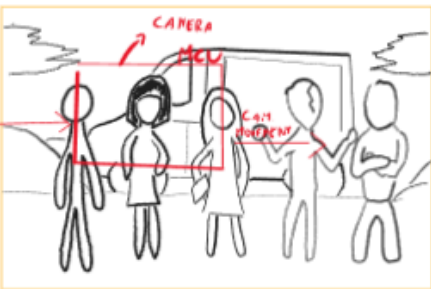
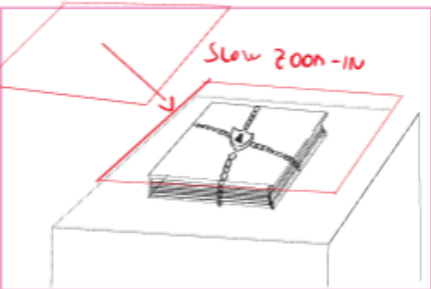
Realizing the catastrophe she has inadvertently unleashed, Aria seeks the help of the remaining members of the Four Wheels Book Club. In them, she sees something Albert has lost: respect for stories, and the belief that they are meant to be shared, not owned by a single person.

One by one, she grants them new abilities, not to dominate narratives, but to channel them. Each member becomes an embodiment of the virtues of literature’s greatest heroes.

After saving the library, the protagonists begin pursuing Albert through a world reshaped by the very stories he has corrupted. As they borrow abilities from famous novels, they gradually uncover the lore behind each tale, deepening their understanding of the heroes whose powers they wield and unlocking new abilities along the way.

Prologue Cinematic

This Storyboard illustrates the main points of the prologue cinematic, until the moment Aria is freed from the Sealed Legend Book.

Character presentation	The Silent Whisper library	The secret passage
		
In this scene, all the characters are presented, as they just arrived in one of the stops of their Book Trips.	This scene presents the library to the viewer.	In this scene, Albert finds a secret passage between the shelves, that brings the club to a hidden room...
The Sealed Legend book	Albert unlocks the book	Aria is freed!
		
Here, the Sealed Legend book is presented, all the scene must have a mystic aura	Albert mysteriously breaks the seal of the book, simply by touching it.	Aria is freed from the book. The cutscene interrupts, and an in-game cinematic starts playing, bringing forward the prologue.

7.2.2 Main development

Albert has rapidly assembled an army of ink-born creatures, which have begun ravaging cities—burning and looting every book they can find. These twisted beings seep through streets and buildings like living shadows, leaving behind trails of blackened pages and dissolved knowledge. Albert's goal is to possess a single, unique copy of every book in existence, thereby gaining absolute control over all culture and erasing any alternative version of it.

Along the way, a darker truth comes to light: Albert's fall is rooted in his growing frustration with a world that no longer values culture or literature. Now convinced that true knowledge is wasted on the masses, he now believes that only a select few are worthy of its power, formed in his Infinite Library. The rest, in his eyes, deserve nothing more than to live as subjects under his rule, kept ignorant and obedient while he reshapes society according to his vision of "true" enlightenment.

The heart of his plan is constructing an ever-growing vertical library on top of the Spine Mountains ([see section 8.5 Spine Mountain](#)) a towering structure of shifting shelves and ink-forged architecture that pierces the skyline. Within it, stolen books are catalogued, sealed, and guarded, forming a monolithic archive where all stories, histories, and ideas are reduced to a single, controlled narrative.

In the final confrontation, the heroes challenge not only his power but his ideology. They argue that culture is not a privilege reserved for the elite, but a shared inheritance meant to uplift everyone. Through confrontation and compassion, they strive to break through his disillusionment and remind him that stories are the strongest when they belong to all.

7.3 Backstory

Hundreds of years before the story of Punchline begins, heroes and fairy creatures lived alongside humans and were not yet confined to the pages of old, dusty books. Magic flowed through the world, intertwined with everyday life, and humans were both fascinated and unsettled by it. Fairy beings were unpredictable, guided by rules that differed from human logic, making them difficult to understand and impossible to control.

Over time, wonder gave way to distrust. Humans began to push these creatures away, confining them to the most remote and inaccessible places: deep within ancient forests, atop the highest mountains, or in corners of the world long forgotten. Many of the fairy tales and legends that survive to this day trace their origins back to that era, telling stories of encounters, conflicts, and fragile alliances between the two worlds.

For some, however, isolation was not enough. Convinced that magic was a threat beyond their control, they believed these creatures had to be eradicated to ensure the survival of humankind. Thus began a long and silent hunt. Strengthened by their numbers and determination, humans succeeded in slaughtering or imprisoning most magical beings, shattering the balance that had once defined the world.

The few survivors vanished into hiding, swearing never to reveal themselves to humanity again. Some retreated into hidden dimensions, while others dissolved into magic itself, leaving behind only echoes and fading memories.

As the centuries passed, the memory of that age faded. The modern world has all but forgotten those times, reducing magic and fairy creatures to mere inventions. Today, they are seen only as baseless fantasies, characters in bedtime stories with no connection to reality.

7.4 Narrative devices

Throughout the game, there will be narrative sequences and dialogues that advance the story, along with optional dialogues within the Van area to further explore the NPCs, learning more about their state of mind, current goals, and background.

As previously mentioned, the game is primarily aimed at the Bartle type of Socializers and, for this reason, the narrative component, while important in providing a compelling and coherent metaphor, will not be the core of the experience.

The story will mainly serve as a guiding thread, supporting the gameplay. The goal is to allow players to jump into the action quickly and enjoy the cooperative experience, while leaving narrative depth as an optional layer for those who wish to explore it.

For this reason, the backstory of the game world, as well as deeper elements related to characters and NPCs, will be entirely optional. Players will be able to discover them through optional dialogues, interactions within the van, and through a Codex accessible from the pause menu. This system will collect information about characters, environments, stories, and literary references, allowing for a gradual and non-intrusive exploration of the lore.

8. The Game World

The game is set in an alternate version of the modern world, where the key difference lies in the real existence of fantastical creatures and magic. However, these elements have remained hidden from most of humanity due to a war that took place centuries ago ([see section 7.3 Backstory](#)).

Following the events of the game, some locations begin to change and transform, blending with the imagery of books and fairy tales. This phenomenon is caused by the uncontrolled use of Albert's power, which alters reality itself, rewriting it according to the distorted logic of the stories he manipulates.

8.1 Cover Hills

This area will likely serve as the first level of the game. It is the hilly region surrounding the library where the adventure begins, and represents the first environment affected by Albert's magic, as well as the place where players will take their first steps.



COVER HILLS CONCEPT ART

The area is now overrun by ink-born creatures. The landscape, once natural and harmonious, is gradually losing its original form. The hills begin to warp, some transforming into massive upside-down books, while the ground ripples like pages moved by the wind. Fragments of text and symbols emerge from the soil.

The first monsters created by Albert are relatively simple and not very intelligent. They act mainly on instinct, attempting to overwhelm the protagonists through sheer numbers, using rudimentary tools and

improvised traps.

The monsters are crudely organized by one of Albert's commanders, a large orc named **Ragh** ([see section 6.2 NPCs](#)).

8.2 Ink Rivers

Originally a vast swamp, this region has been heavily transformed by Albert's magic. It is now characterized by dark, viscous waterways resembling liquid ink, in which it is easy to become trapped. The terrain is unstable and dangerous, forcing players to move carefully.

To traverse the area, players must make use of environmental elements such as vines hanging from unnaturally large trees or jump across rocks and platforms that occasionally emerge from the dark pools.



INK RIVERS CONCEPT ART

The environment provides a natural advantage to enemies, which can hide beneath the surface of the ink and launch sudden ambushes. As a result, the creatures in this area are more dangerous, using the terrain to strike and retreat quickly.

Before Albert's arrival, it was said that a legendary witch lived at the heart of this swampy forest, known for her ability to appear in different places as if she could bend space itself, called **Lady Millicent**. Now, she has become one of his servants. ([see section 6.2 NPCs](#))

8.3 Flyleaf

Flyleaf is a large city now heavily distorted by Albert's power. Skyscrapers and modern streets are interwoven with the ruins of ancient towers and crumbling castles, creating a surreal and fragmented urban landscape where past and present collide.



FLYLEAF CONCEPT ART

(WAR - RUINED CITY BY PAVEL SIVASH)

Ink-born creatures have ravaged the city, setting it ablaze and looting every home and building where books might be found. Entire districts lie in ruins, and most of the inhabitants have fled, leaving behind a silent, devastated environment.

In this area, enemies are significantly more aggressive and dangerous, and some of the strongest foes in the game begin to appear. Large portions of the city are still burning, with fires spreading across streets and buildings.

Here, the monsters are more organized. They have established barricades, fortified positions, and small strongholds.

Overseeing the area is one of Albert's most powerful commanders, the **Bibliodragon** ([see section 6.2 NPCs](#)).

8.4 Page Valley

This area lies just before Spine Mountain. The valley is covered in peculiar flowers whose petals are replaced by small fragments of written paper, each inscribed with faint, shifting words. The air is filled with paper birds gliding silently through the sky, and at first glance, the place feels untouched, almost detached from the destruction seen in Flyleaf.

However, this apparent calm hides a more subtle danger. The ink-born creatures that inhabit this area appear more refined and composed, moving with an almost graceful elegance. These beings fight with precision and coordination, making them significantly more lethal despite their less aggressive appearance.

Whispers of fragmented sentences drift through the valley, and some of the written petals react when approached, whispering about forgotten stories or concealed paths.



PAGE VALLEY CONCEPT ART

Overseeing the area is one of Albert's most imposing commanders, **Kromar the Titan** ([see section 6.2 NPCs](#)). A towering giant of immense proportions, he sits along the mountainside, watching over the valley.

8.5 Spine Mountain

This is the final area of the game. At the peak of a harsh, snow-swept mountain, Albert's **Infinite Library** is taking shape. Here, ink-born creatures tirelessly transport massive blocks of material, flying or climbing along the mountain's jagged surface, contributing to the construction of Albert's grand and distorted vision: a colossal library meant to contain all human knowledge, hoarded and controlled exclusively by him and a chosen few, filled with books looted from across the world.



SPINE MOUNTAIN CONCEPT ART

In this region, the effects of Albert's power reach their peak. The landscape is heavily warped, with fragments of parchment and torn pages spiraling endlessly around the mountain, carried by unnatural currents of magical energy. The entire area appears frozen in a perpetual golden hour, casting long shadows and bathing the environment in an eerie, almost sacred light.

Here, words and phrases materialize into solid forms when spoken.

At the top of the **Infinite Library**, Albert continuously harnesses this power, summoning relentless waves of ink-born creatures to defend his domain. The ascent toward him represents the ultimate challenge, where players must face both overwhelming enemies and a reality that no longer follows the rules of the natural world.

9. Media List

This is a list of all the media that needs to be outsourced to the artists that will be hired once the game begins development. Obvious ones such as buttons for navigating all the menus and controller and keyboard buttons images for the UI are omitted.

9.1 Game assets

9.1.1 Playable Characters

For each of the four playable characters:

- 3D model
- Textures
- Animations:
 - Idle
 - Movement (walk/run)
 - Dash/Dodge
 - Combos
 - L-Ink Combo interactions
 - Hit reactions
 - Knockdown
 - Ink corruption transformation
 - Revival
 - Emotes
- Vfx for all the attacks and animations
- Sfx for all the attacks and animations

9.1.2 NPCs

- 3D models for:
 - Aria
 - Victoria
 - Old Gary (NPC version)
 - Albert
- Animations for every NPC:
 - Idle
 - Dialogue/talking
 - Gestures (in response to Player's Emote)
- Sfx for every NPC:
 - Generic mumbling Sfx.
 - Or full Dubbing.

9.1.3 Enemies

For each enemy (described in [section 6.2 NPCs](#)):

- 3D model
- Animations:
 - Idle
 - Movement
 - Attacks
 - Hit reaction
 - Death
- Variants (color swaps)
- Sfx for every enemy and every enemy attack (some can obviously be reused).

9.1.4 Bosses

- 3D models and animations, Vfx and Sfx for all the bosses described in [section 6.2 NPCs](#).
- Thematic music tracks for all the bosses.

9.2 Environmental assets

9.2.1 World and Levels assets

For each area described in [section 8 The Game World](#), the necessary assets to create levels suitable for the aesthetic of each area needs to be created. **Some examples are:**

- 3D Models:
 - Trees
 - Rocks
 - Books
 - Pages
 - Buildings
 - Medieval ruins
 - Levers
 - Gates
 - Crates (light/heavy)
 - Moving platforms
 - Magical crystals
 - Cosmetic items blueprints
- Sufficient music tracks (at least two per area)

In this section also the 3D models for the Game World Map ([see section 5.2.3 The World Map](#)) must be mentioned:

- Van (map version)
- World map
- Level nodes
- Paths
- Progress indicators

9.2.2 Van Hub

For the Van Area, five different versions must be created, one reflecting each of the areas described in [section 8 The Game World](#), reusing some of the assets of the World and Level assets. Additionally, these assets are required:

- 3D models:
 - Wardrobe
 - Campfire
 - Picnic area
 - Arm wrestling table
 - Rest area
 - Seating area
- Animations:
 - Contextual emotes (Such as the one to toast, [see Section 5.5.1 Van](#) for other examples)
 - Minigame animations (Arm-Wrestling)
- Music for the area

9.3 Interface assets

The assets listed here are the ones required in the menus and the in-game HUD. Some of them will be shared among them (such as UI feedback Sfx), and with other parts of the game. For clarity, it will be clearly mentioned when the assets used are declared in another part of the Media List.

9.3.1 Main Menu Assets

- Main menu Background art.
- Background music.

9.3.2 Codex Menu

- The codex includes information abouts all the monsters and NPCs of the game, and their models will be included in this section (assets already declared in the *Enemies* and *Bosses* sections of the Media List).
- Also, the animations for all the attacks and models of the Characters will be present in the **Characters** section (assets already declared in the *Playable Characters* section of the Media List).

9.3.3 In game HUD

- Health bars
- Inspiration meter
- Achievement icons

9.4 Customization Assets

- Outfit pieces:
 - Head
 - Upper body
 - Lower body
- Special outfits

9.5 Musical score inspirations

- Music inspiration for the game (These reference tracks can be shared with the artists working on the soundtrack to communicate the desired emotional tone and style of the music):
 - Unreal @krynez
 - Siinamota - young girl A (piano version) @pira
 - My turn @vaped
 - Drowning Love "Speed up loop" (piano version) @Flavio.Belardo
 - Golden hour (piano version) @sou
 - La Folla (piano version) @sou
 - How cruel @Sarah Lola
 - Flower Dance (piano version) @MIDI Piano
 - Floating piano @yoav shati
 - Kikou - Hole-dwelling piano cover @Reiva piano
 - Monitoring (piano cover) @Pira

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10. Prototype

The prototype will consist of a vertical slice of the final gameplay experience. Only two characters will be playable.

Since the combat system represents the core of the game, it will also be the primary focus of the vertical slice. As such, it will be fully implemented, including basic combos and L-Ink Combos. However, the exact move sets and animations may differ from the final product, as the prototype will be developed without the support of a dedicated 3D artist to create custom animations, and not the complete move set will be showcased for the same reason.

Visual assets will primarily be sourced from official asset stores and will later be fully replaced with original art created by an artist, as outlined in the TDD.

The vertical slice will be set in a mid-game scenario, giving players access to mechanics and challenges representative of the full experience. After pressing Start, the demo will begin immediately, without additional setup. A printed reference sheet with the basic controls will be provided.

The prototype will not include online functionality and will support local co-op only, in line with the core cooperative design of the game.

The prototype will not include any form of customization.

The full pause menu will not be accessible in the prototype; instead, a simplified version will be implemented to cover only essential functions.

For the demo, full controller support will be implemented to ensure accessibility and ease of play.